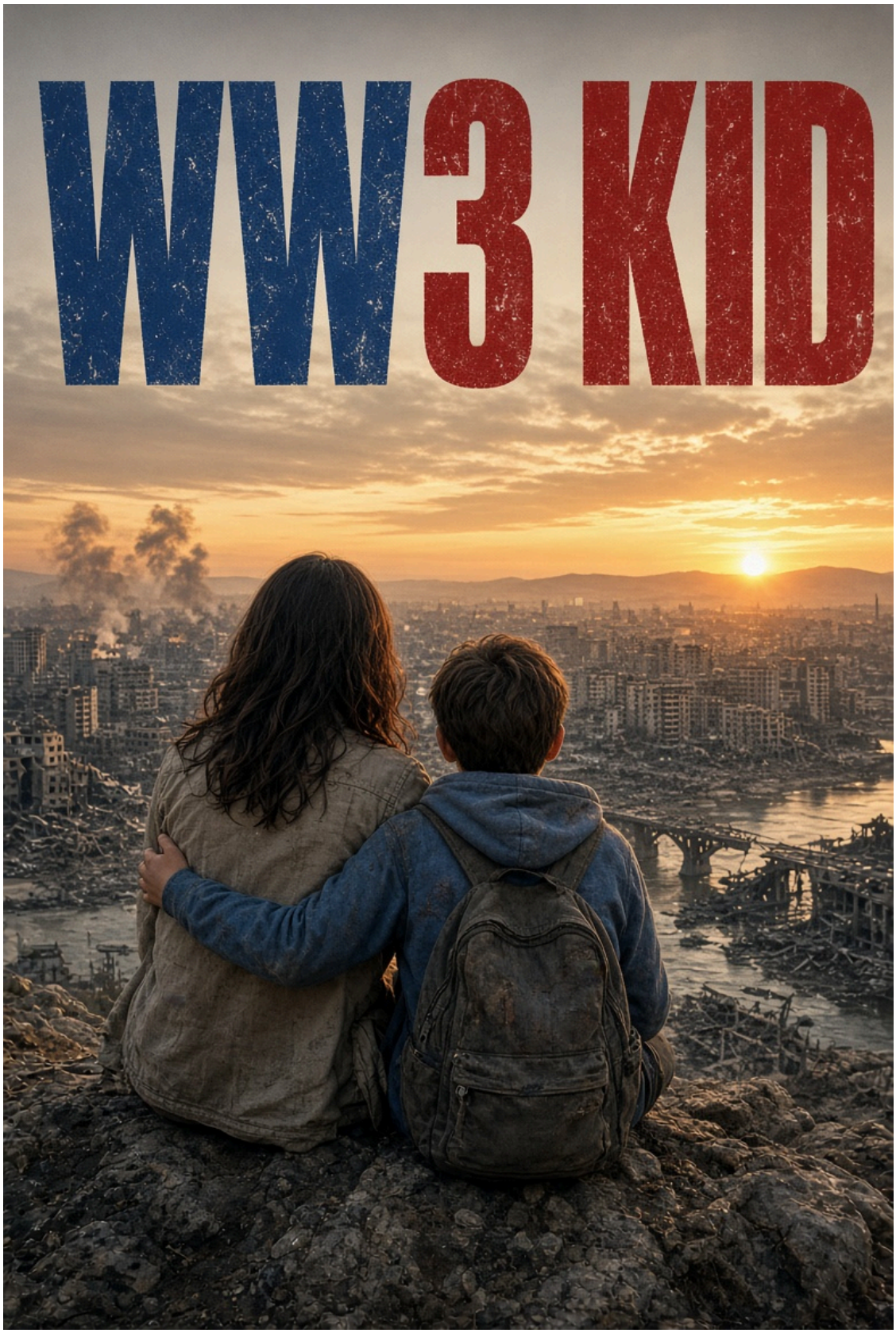
By Lynden Pennington



By Lynden Pennington

WW3 KID

A long way to safe harbor

By Lynden Pennington

To Resaca Middle School

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter One: Falling

I want to tell you something before this story even really starts: I survived a plane crash in the middle of a war, at eleven years old, in a field in the north of England I couldn't have found on a map if you paid me.

I know how that sounds. I know it sounds like the kind of thing that happens in a movie, or a video game, or a book somebody made up. I used to think that too, before it happened to me — that disasters were things that happened to other people, in other places, on the news, safely far away from anything that actually touched my life. Turns out that's not true. Turns out disasters don't check first to see if you're ready. They don't check your age, or your grades, or whether you've got a math test on Thursday. They just arrive, uninvited, and change everything.

I remember green rushing up too fast outside the window. I remember my mom's hand locked around mine so tight it almost hurt, and not letting go, not once, not through any of it. I remember a sound that wasn't one crash but a bunch of them stacked on top of each other, metal tearing away from metal, the whole plane plowing a long black scar through wet grass, throwing up mud and turf in every direction like the ground itself was trying to fight back against something that had no business landing on it.

And then, after all that noise — quiet. So quiet I could hear a single bird chirping in a hedge somewhere close by, going on with its normal morning like nothing had happened. Because for the bird, nothing had. The bird didn't know a plane wasn't supposed to fall out of the sky.

"Milo." My mom's voice, scratchy, right next to me. "Milo, baby, look at me."

By Lynden Pennington

I looked at her. Blood was running into my eyebrow. I was holding a chess knight so hard my knuckles hurt, and I have no idea, to this day, how I never once let go of it.

“I’m okay,” I told her. It wasn’t totally true. It was the truest thing I could manage right then.

That’s where this story gets the hardest. But it’s not where it starts. To really understand how I ended up falling out of the sky into a stranger’s sheep field, you have to go back six days, to a completely normal morning, in a kitchen in New York City, before I knew any of this was coming — before the sirens outside my window meant anything more than traffic, before a war I’d barely paid attention to reached out and grabbed hold of my entire life.

So let me back up. Let me start at the beginning, the way it actually happened, one ordinary morning at a time.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Two: Sirens

Six days before the crash, I had no idea any of it was coming. I was just sitting at the kitchen counter in our apartment in New York City, eating eggs and trying to beat my high score on a game on my phone, while my mom told me — for the hundredth time — that I was going to be late for school.

Our apartment was on the fourth floor of an old brick building on 111th Street, up a staircase with a fourth step that always creaked no matter how carefully you stepped on it. The kitchen was small — you could basically stand in the middle of it and touch the fridge and the stove at the same time — but the window over the sink looked out at a strip of sky between two other buildings, and on clear mornings you could catch a little slice of orange sunrise squeezed right between the rooftops. There was a crack in my bedroom ceiling shaped like a dinosaur that I'd been making up stories about since I was six.

"You say that every day," I told her. "I'm never late."

"You're never late because I say it every day."

It was an ordinary morning, in every way that mattered. My mom, Clare, made eggs. I rearranged them more than I ate them. Outside, New York did its normal New York things — trucks honking down on the avenue, a lady down the hall practicing violin so badly it almost sounded like a bird getting stepped on, the smell of bagels from the shop on the corner drifting up through the window my mom always forgot to close all the way, pigeons arguing with each other on the fire escape rail like they owned the place.

I didn't know it yet, but that was the last normal morning I'd have for a long, long time.

By Lynden Pennington

See, there was a war starting. I'd heard bits of it on the news, the way you hear things when you're a kid — mostly background noise, adults using serious voices, words like "conflict" and "crisis" and "escalation." It didn't feel real. Wars happened in other places, in history books, in video games. Not in my kitchen. Not in my city.

My mom worked in shipping, tracking cargo boats and planes moving all over the world for a company that did business practically everywhere. It sounds boring — she always joked it was "boring in an important way" — but it meant she noticed things most people didn't. She noticed when shipping routes across the ocean started changing without warning. She noticed when her company's office in another country went quiet for four whole days. Little signs, the kind normal people miss, but she wasn't normal people. She said the pipes of the whole world were starting to make a noise she didn't like.

She didn't tell me any of that at first. I found out later she'd known something was wrong almost two weeks before she said a single word to me about it. She let me have my math test. She let me have Thursday. She let Deshawn keep teaching me to skateboard, badly, for as long as she possibly could.

Then one Monday, everything changed.

My mom sat me down before school, which she never did, and I knew right away something was wrong. She had that face — the one moms get when they've been awake at 4 a.m. deciding exactly how to say something.

"Milo," she said. "I need you to listen to me for a minute. And I need you to know I'm not scared."

She was scared. I could tell. Moms think kids can't tell when they're scared, but we can. It's in the eyes. It's in how still they hold their hands.

By Lynden Pennington

“Is it the war?” I asked, because I’d been putting the pieces together for days without saying anything either. I guess that runs in the family.

She looked surprised I’d said it out loud, like she’d been bracing herself to be the one who had to say the word first. “Yes,” she said. “It’s the war.”

I didn’t know yet what that word was about to cost us. I didn’t know that in five days, I’d be falling out of the sky over a country I’d never even visited. I just sat there, eating eggs I wasn’t really eating, and let the word settle into the room like weather.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Three: The Word Nobody Wanted to Say

For six days after that, nobody on the news would even say the word “war” out loud. They used other words instead — “conflict,” “escalation,” “situation” — like if grown-ups just avoided the actual word, the actual thing might stay away too. I noticed that trick pretty fast. Kids notice when adults are avoiding a word. It’s like when someone won’t tell you how bad a grade actually is — the dodging tells you everything.

School felt strange that week too, in a way I couldn’t totally explain at the time. Teachers kept the news off in the classroom but I’d catch them checking their phones during lunch duty with this tight, worried look. Deshawn noticed it too — he was the one who first said, out loud, at recess, “Something’s happening, right? Like, actually happening?” — and I remember not knowing how to answer him, because some part of me already knew and didn’t want to be the one to say it first.

My mom’s office got quiet that week too. She still went to work, but she started keeping her phone face-up on her desk all the time, screen unlocked, like she was waiting for something. I know this because she told me about it later — about her boss, a guy named Aaron, calling her into his office and closing the door, which apparently he never did.

“You need to think about Milo,” he told her, and showed her some report about insurance companies refusing to cover ships and planes going in and out of certain cities. New York was on that list.

That same week, my Aunt Renata called from Switzerland, where she lived with her husband Marc near a lake with actual mountains around it. I only heard my mom’s side of the call, sitting at the kitchen table pretending to do homework while actually listening to every word.

By Lynden Pennington

“Come,” Renata said, loud enough that I could hear it even through the phone. “Both of you. There’s room. The flights out are only going to get worse, Clare, not better.”

“I have a job,” my mom said.

“You have a son.”

My mom didn’t say anything back to that. I remember the silence on the other end of that call more than almost anything else from that whole week — the sound of my mom deciding something without saying it out loud yet, the phone pressed against her ear, her eyes closed, her free hand gripping the edge of the counter like she needed it to stay standing.

That night, she told me. Not gently, exactly, but honestly, which I appreciated even though I was scared.

“We might be going to Switzerland for a while,” she said. “To stay with Aunt Renata. Just until things settle down.”

“For how long?”

“I don’t know, baby.”

I nodded like this was just the next item on a to-do list, because that’s kind of how I deal with big scary things — I try to turn them into something I can manage, like a school project. “Can I bring my chess set?” I asked.

“You can bring whatever fits in one bag.”

I thought about that seriously, the way I think about a chess move, weighing every piece. One bag. It didn’t sound like much. It was about to turn out to be even less than I thought.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Four: What Fits in One Bag

Turns out, when you have four days to leave your whole life behind, you learn pretty fast what actually matters.

My mom packed and repacked our bags something like three different times. Each time, the pile of "important stuff" got smaller. The first time, I tried to bring basically my whole room — every book, half my clothes, an old shoebox of cards I hadn't touched in two years but suddenly could not imagine living without. By the third time, I had exactly one bag, and here's what actually made the cut: three books, my good chess set — not the travel one, the real wooden one — a photo of my dad I didn't even know my mom knew I had (I kept it folded up in one of my socks, don't ask me why, it just felt like a place nobody would look), and one skateboard wheel. Just the wheel, not the whole board. I couldn't really explain why I needed it. I just did. Some things don't need a reason.

My mom's stuff was harder to watch her pack. She kept picking things up and putting them back down — a coffee mug my dad had given her a long time ago, a stack of photographs, a sweater that used to be her mom's. In the end her bag looked almost exactly like mine. One bag. That's apparently how much of a whole life you can actually carry when it comes down to it.

Deshawn came over on the last night. He showed up already talking, the way he always did, mid-sentence about some kid at school who'd tried to skate down the handrail outside the library and eaten it spectacularly in front of a whole crowd of eighth graders. That was Deshawn — he had about four hundred stories going at all times, and somehow they were always funnier out loud than they had any right to be, full of sound effects and terrible impressions of teachers. He was wearing the same beat-up

green hoodie he wore basically every day of his life, and his board was tucked under one arm even though there was nowhere to skate on a fourth-floor fire escape.

We climbed out my window and sat there for a while, not really talking much, because that's just how me and Deshawn are sometimes — we don't need to fill up every second with words. Below us, the street did its normal thing, cabs honking, someone's dog barking at absolutely nothing, the violin lady two floors down sawing away at the same four notes she never quite got right. I kept trying to memorize it all without looking like that's what I was doing — the exact orange of the streetlight coming on, the smell of somebody's dinner drifting up from an open window, Deshawn picking at a loose thread on his sneaker like he always did when he was thinking about something he didn't want to say out loud yet.

"You'll come back," he said, finally, after a long quiet stretch. It wasn't really a question.

"Yeah," I said. "Obviously."

Neither of us said anything for a minute after that. I looked at him instead of the street — really looked, the way you don't usually bother to look at somebody you see every single day — like some part of me already knew I was going to need to remember his face for a while.

We didn't hug, because we were eleven and eleven-year-old boys don't really do that, at least not out loud where anyone might see. But right when he was about to head down the stairs, he turned around fast and hugged me hard, then bolted before either of us could get embarrassed about it. I heard him yell "SEE YOU, IDIOT" from two floors down, which is basically Deshawn for "I'm really going to miss you." I yelled back "SEE YOU, BIGGER IDIOT," which is basically Milo for the exact same thing. Then I

just stood there on the fire escape a while longer, listening to his skateboard wheels clatter off down the sidewalk until I couldn't hear them anymore.

My mom's boss sent her an email that just said *Go. Don't look back.* My grandma, back in Ohio, called about eleven times trying to convince us to come stay with her instead, but my mom said Switzerland had actual mountains between us and the war, and Ohio mostly just had a Wendy's. My grandma laughed at that, even while she was crying, which is a very grandma combination of things to do at once.

On our last night in the apartment, I couldn't sleep. I lay in bed staring at the crack in the ceiling shaped like a dinosaur that I used to make up stories about when I was little, and I kept thinking about how weird it was that everything still looked exactly the same — my posters, my desk, the dent in the wall from the one time I threw a controller — even though in a few hours, none of it would be mine anymore.

I fell asleep holding the photo of my dad, taken back out of my sock, held in my hand like a little kid holds a stuffed animal, even though I was eleven and definitely too old for that.

The next morning, we went to the airport. I didn't know it yet, but it would be a long, long time before either of us slept in a bed that belonged to us again.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Five: JFK

The airport did not look like a place that was part of a war. That's the thing I kept noticing, over and over, on our way through it — how normal everything still seemed, even then. It still smelled like burnt coffee and jet fuel, that specific airport smell that's the same in basically every terminal on Earth. There was still a shop selling sunglasses for way too much money, and a guy in a tiny cart zipping some old lady past us going way faster than seemed safe. Somewhere behind us, a little kid was having a full-blown meltdown about a pretzel, and honestly? I was kind of grateful for it. It was nice to hear a problem that small, echoing off all that shiny floor and glass.

But if you looked closer, you could tell something was different. The security line was about three times longer than normal, and it was full of families instead of the usual business people in suits, everyone dragging bags stuffed too full to zip all the way. Everybody had that same tight, careful look on their faces, like they were all trying really hard not to look scared in front of their kids. The departure board — that big wall of flickering letters you could hear clicking and turning even from across the terminal — kept updating with new words: CANCELLED. CANCELLED. DELAYED. CANCELLED. Every few minutes, a little wave of quiet would move through the whole terminal as another flight just disappeared off the list, like the whole room was holding its breath at the same time, over and over.

Our flight to Zurich still said ON TIME, though, and I watched that word like it was a video game health bar, waiting for it to drop.

"Mom." I nudged her and nodded at a TV mounted above a closed shop. The sound was off, but you didn't need sound. It was footage of smoke

rising over some city skyline — I didn't recognize which one, but it didn't really matter, because it hit me for the first time that it could have been any city. It could have been ours.

"Don't watch that," my mom said, steering me toward our gate by the shoulder. I didn't argue. But I'd already seen it, and not watching didn't un-see it.

At the gate, my mom called my grandma even though we hadn't even boarded yet.

"We're at the gate," she said. "We're okay. We're about to board."

"Call me the second the wheels touch down," my grandma said, loud enough I could hear it through the phone. "The second, Clare."

"I promise," my mom said.

I didn't think anything of that promise at the time. I would think about it a lot, later.

I spent the wait working through a chess problem on my travel set, moving the pieces around slow and careful, because thinking hard about something small is honestly a pretty good way to not think about something huge. My mom let me do it without bugging me, which I appreciated, because I think she needed the quiet as much as I did. Across from us, a family with two younger kids was doing something similar, the mom reading a picture book out loud in a low, steady voice, and I remember thinking that was probably her version of my chess problem — something small and familiar to hold onto while everything else got strange.

Boarding started forty minutes late. The gate agent's voice over the speaker had that fake-cheerful sound adults get when they're trying really hard to sound calm for people who can tell it's fake.

By Lynden Pennington

“Thank you for your patience today,” she said, and as I walked down the jet bridge holding my mom’s hand — which I would normally have been too old for, except right then I didn’t care — I remember thinking that was a weird thing to thank us for. Patience. Like that was the hard part of any of this.

I looked back once, right before the jet bridge curved out of sight of the terminal, at the wide windows and the gray New York sky beyond them, and some part of me — the part that still half-believed we’d be back in a few weeks, a month at most — waved goodbye without really meaning to. I didn’t know yet that it would be the last time I saw that particular sky for a long, long time.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Six: Wheels Up

The plane was fuller than I'd ever seen a plane before, every single seat taken, and the overhead bins were crammed with the kind of luggage you see when people are running from something instead of going on vacation — duffel bags instead of nice rolling suitcases, pillows people had brought from their own beds, a lady a few rows up hugging a small dog carrier like it held the most precious thing in the entire world. I noticed a man across the aisle clutching a violin case on his lap instead of stowing it, like he wasn't willing to risk it out of his sight, and I remember thinking about the violin lady down the hall from our old apartment and wondering, for just a second, if she'd ever get on a plane like this one someday too.

I got the window seat, like always, and pressed my forehead against the plastic the way I'd been doing since I was small enough that my mom had to lift me up to see out at all.

"Are we really going to be okay?" I asked, still looking out the window instead of at her, using my best casual voice, the voice you use when you've decided in advance you might not actually want the real answer.

"We're really going to be okay," my mom said.

I believed her. I want that on the record. I completely believed her, right up until the moment I very much did not.

The plane pushed back from the gate a little before five in the evening. It took forever to actually take off — extra security checks, the pilot said, "given current conditions," which is grown-up talk for *we're all a little nervous too*. When we finally lifted off, the sky outside my window was this incredible color, orange bleeding into deep blue-gray, and it was so pretty it almost didn't feel real, like a screensaver instead of an actual sky.

By Lynden Pennington

I watched Manhattan shrink underneath us — all those grid streets, all those lights blinking on for the evening, the two rivers wrapped around the island like it was something worth protecting, which, I guess, it was. I found our neighborhood, or thought I did, a tiny cluster of lights somewhere near the top of the island, and pressed my finger to the cold window glass right over the spot, like I could hold it there a second longer just by touching it.

“Bye, New York,” I said quietly, to the window, not looking at my mom, because some things you can only say if nobody’s watching your face while you say them.

She took my hand. I let her. I think that told her more than anything I could’ve actually said out loud.

Dinner came and went — some sad little tray of pasta I barely touched, my stomach too full of nerves to have room for food. The cabin lights dimmed for the long nighttime flight across the ocean. Somewhere over the dark middle of the Atlantic, about four hours in, I fell asleep against my mom’s shoulder with my chess set still open in my lap, one knight still stuck in my hand where I’d been holding it when I dozed off, the last thing I remember thinking being some half-formed worry about whether Deshawn had actually landed that kickflip yet without me there to see it.

I didn’t wake up again until the sound.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Seven: The Sound Before the Sound

Here's the thing about the sound — nobody who was on that plane agrees on exactly what it was. Some people say it was a bang. Some say it was more like a crack, or a slam, like a door shutting somewhere way down below the floor of the plane. But I remember it differently than probably anybody else on board, because what I actually noticed first wasn't a sound at all. It was my mom's hand squeezing mine, tight, before either of us was even fully awake — like some part of her brain knew we were in danger a half-second before the rest of her did.

Then the real sound hit. A hard crack from somewhere behind us, the kind you feel in your chest before you even hear it in your ears, and the whole plane lurched sideways so hard that drink carts slammed into their brakes and stuff went flying out of the overhead bins into the aisle — bags, a blanket, somebody's shoe, all of it tumbling down the aisle like the plane itself had been picked up and shaken. The seatbelt light chimed on, and it made this small, cheerful little *ding*, which felt completely insane given everything else that was happening.

"Milo—" My mom already had my seatbelt in her hands, checking it, her fingers not quite steady.

The cabin lights flickered, went out, came back on dim and orange. A few rows up, a woman started praying, quiet and steady, in a language I didn't know, and honestly that scared me more than screaming would have, because it meant grown-ups already understood this was really, really bad. Somewhere behind us, a baby started crying, and then another one, like the sound was spreading backward through the plane the same way the fear was.

By Lynden Pennington

The pilot's voice came over the speaker, and all the calm from before was gone from it completely. "This is the flight deck. We've sustained damage and are declaring an emergency. Cabin crew, take your seats. All passengers, brace positions, now."

Nobody on that flight ever found out for sure exactly what happened — whether it was a missile that hit us by accident, aimed at some military plane that wasn't even us, or some kind of mechanical failure that just felt like an attack because of everything else going on in the world. There was an investigation, years later, that figured out it was almost certainly the first thing — a case of very bad timing, made by somebody who never even knew our flight number, in a stretch of sky that should have been closed to fighting and wasn't, not that night.

None of that mattered in the moment, though. What mattered was my mom's face, turned toward mine in the dim orange light, and the picture on the little safety card in the seat pocket that I'd looked at on every flight of my life and never once thought I'd actually need.

"Bend forward," my mom said, her voice steadier than I think she actually felt. "Head down, arms over your head. Like we practiced."

We had never practiced. She said it anyway. I think sometimes a mom's voice is the last solid thing standing in a world that's falling apart, and she wasn't about to let hers fall too.

Oxygen masks dropped down the aisle in this yellow cascade, swinging on their little tubes, exactly like in the safety video, except real. My mom pulled mine over my face first, then hers, and bent forward over me the way you'd bend over something you were trying to protect from the sky itself, her whole body curled around mine like a shell.

By Lynden Pennington

I wasn't thinking about Switzerland. I wasn't thinking about the war, or Deshawn, or anything at all really, except one thing, over and over, like a heartbeat: *we're going to be okay, we're going to be okay, we're going to be okay*.

I don't actually know if I believed it. But I said it in my head anyway, because sometimes that's the only thing left to do.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Eight: Impact

I don't have one clear memory of the crash. What I have instead is a bunch of little pieces, like a photo that got torn up and only halfway put back together.

I remember green. An unbelievable amount of green, rushing up way too fast in the gray early morning light — fields I didn't have a name for yet, with hedges stitched between them like the seams on my chess set's case. I remember the sound wasn't just one crash, but a bunch of them in a row, metal tearing away from metal, the back part of the plane going one way and the front part skidding another way, plowing this long black scar through wet grass, throwing up chunks of turf that hung in the air for a second before raining back down around us.

I remember my mom's hand, still in mine, through literally all of it. I asked her later how she never let go, through all that flipping and shaking and crashing, and she said she didn't remember deciding to hold on. Her hand just didn't open. I believe her. I think some part of a mom's body just refuses to let go, no matter what.

Then: quiet. The kind of quiet that feels loud after that much noise — metal settling and groaning, some far-off dripping I didn't want to think too hard about, and underneath it all, a bird chirping outside somewhere in the hedges, going on with its normal morning like nothing had happened at all. Because for the bird, nothing had. The bird didn't know a plane wasn't supposed to fall out of the sky.

"Milo." My mom's voice came out scratchy. "Milo, baby, look at me."

By Lynden Pennington

I was already looking at her. There was blood running from a cut above my eyebrow into my eyelashes, and I still had that stupid chess knight clenched in my fist — I have no idea how I never let go of it either.

“I’m okay,” I told her, which wasn’t totally true, but it was the truest thing I could manage to say right then.

Around us, the plane was a mess of torn-open seats and scattered bags, gray morning light coming in through a fuselage that had been peeled open like a soda can. Some people were moving around us, unbuckling seatbelts, calling out names, one man crawling over a collapsed seatback toward a voice I recognized, distantly, as belonging to the guy with the violin case. Some people weren’t moving, and I made myself stop looking at that part pretty fast, focusing instead on my mom’s hands, my mom’s voice, anything that was still solid and still ours.

Later, we found out that out of the hundred and eighty-six people who got on that plane in New York, ninety-one of us walked or got carried out of that field alive. Almost exactly half. I think about that number a lot, even now. I don’t think I’ll ever stop thinking about it, and I don’t think that’s a bad thing. I think it means I understand how lucky we were.

“We have to get out,” my mom said, working my seatbelt loose. “Can you walk? Does anything feel wrong when you move?”

“I don’t think so.” I was still holding the knight. “Mom. Mom, did we — is this —”

“We’re alive,” she said, and pulled me up out of the seat, into the wreckage, into the cold, green, gray morning, and that was the only sentence either of us had left that meant anything. *We’re alive*. Everything else, we’d have to figure out on foot.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Nine: The Field

We had crash-landed, it turned out, in a sheep field belonging to a farmer named Hugh Alderton, about two miles from a village called Thornfield Beck, in a part of England so far out in the hills that nobody even noticed the crash for almost forty minutes.

The field itself was huge and sloped, cut up into sections by low stone walls that had probably been standing there for a couple hundred years, the grass wet enough that it soaked straight through my shoes in about ten seconds. Sheep — actual sheep, dozens of them, with dirty gray wool and black faces — had scattered to the far end of the field and stood there in a clump, staring at us like we were the weirdest thing they'd ever seen, which, fair enough, we probably were. Beyond the wall, the land rolled up into hills the color of moss, dotted here and there with more stone walls climbing right up the slopes like somebody had drawn them on with a ruler. It didn't look like anywhere I'd ever been. It didn't look like anywhere at all, really — just green, and gray sky, and quiet.

Forty minutes is a long time when you're standing in a wrecked plane in the middle of nowhere. People wandered around calling out names. Some people just sat down hard in the wet grass and didn't get up for a while, not because they were hurt, but because their bodies just sort of stopped working right for a bit.

My mom helped where she could — she'd taken a first aid class once for her job, years ago, and it turned out she remembered more of it than either of us expected. She helped a man with a cut arm. She sat with an old woman who was shaking too hard to talk, just holding her hand.

By Lynden Pennington

I found a kid near the wing section — younger than me, maybe eight, sitting alone and crying without making any sound at all, no parents anywhere in sight. I didn't really think about it. I just walked over and sat down next to him in the wet grass and put my hand on his back, the way you'd calm down a scared dog, and didn't say anything.

His mom found him a few minutes later — she'd been just twenty feet away the whole time, searching through the wreckage — and when she scooped him up, she made this sound I still think about sometimes, a sound like relief and terror mixed together into one noise.

"You didn't have to do that," my mom told me later.

I shrugged. "He looked like how I felt."

A giant man with a border collie came over the rise of the field not long after that — Hugh, the farmer whose land we'd landed in. He was probably sixty, built like a stone wall himself, wearing a flat cap and a wax jacket that looked older than I was, and his dog stuck to his heel the whole time like it was sewn there. He didn't scream or freeze up or do any of the stuff you'd expect from a guy who'd just found a crashed plane in his sheep pasture. He just ran straight at the wreckage, already talking into a radio clipped to his jacket, and started pulling people free of seats like it was just another day's farm work — steady, quick, like his hands already knew what to do before his brain had caught up.

"You're all right," he kept saying, over and over, in an accent I'd never heard outside a movie, rolling and thick. "Help's coming. You're all right now." He said it to everybody, the same words every time, like it was a spell he was casting to keep the whole field calm.

I remember, at one point, catching sight of the plane itself properly for the first time in full daylight — really seeing it, not just fragments of it — and

being shocked at how small it looked lying broken open in that huge field, when it had felt like the entire world just a few hours earlier, sealed and roaring and impossible to escape. Something that big, brought down to something that looked, from far enough away, almost like a toy somebody had thrown too hard.

It took another hour before the first ambulance made it up the narrow road from the village. In that hour, ninety-one strangers sat together in a wet green field in the north of England, most of us quiet, some of us crying, all of us alive in a way that didn't feel like relief yet. It felt more like an accident that hadn't finished happening.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Ten: The Long Walk

Nobody official told us to start walking. It just sort of happened — a few people first, then more, then basically the whole field, moving together toward a gap in the stone wall where Hugh had come through, because standing around a wrecked plane started to feel worse than doing something, anything, even if that something was just putting one foot in front of the other.

Hugh led the way, his dog trotting circles around the group like she was herding us the same way she herded sheep, and I guess in a way she was. The ground was uneven and soaked through, and every few steps somebody would stumble on a hidden rut or a half-buried rock, and somebody else would reach out and catch them without even really thinking about it, strangers grabbing strangers' arms like we'd known each other for years instead of forty minutes.

My mom kept one hand on my shoulder the entire way, like she was afraid that if she let go, even for a second, I might just disappear into the gray morning. I didn't mind. I kept one hand curled around the strap of the bag I'd somehow managed not to lose in the crash — my whole life, or what was left of it, in one soggy canvas bag.

The walk to Thornfield Beck was almost two miles, along a farm track that turned into a narrow paved lane the closer we got, hedgerows rising up on both sides thick enough that you couldn't see much past them except sky. Every so often we'd pass a gate, and behind it, more fields, more sheep, more of that endless rolling green that didn't look like anything I'd ever seen out my old bedroom window.

By Lynden Pennington

Theo walked near me most of the way, not talking, just close, the way you stay close to somebody after you've been scared together. His mom, Yasmin, carried him part of the way when his legs finally gave out from exhaustion, and I remember my own legs starting to shake around the same point, adrenaline draining out of me all at once and leaving behind something heavier and more tired than I'd ever felt in my life.

"Nearly there," Hugh kept calling back over his shoulder, again and again, like a countdown. "Nearly there now."

I didn't believe him the first four times he said it. By the fifth time, I noticed rooftops.

Thornfield Beck came into view slowly, the way places do when you're walking instead of driving — first just a church spire poking up over a hill, then a cluster of gray stone roofs, then smoke curling up from actual chimneys, which felt like the most incredible thing I'd ever seen, proof that somewhere ahead of us, people were doing normal things like making breakfast, completely unaware that ninety-one strangers were about to walk into their morning and change it forever.

Word had already reached the village somehow — probably Hugh's radio call — because by the time we reached the edge of town, people were already coming out of their houses to meet us. An old man in a bathrobe. A woman still in her nightgown, carrying an armful of towels. A kid about my age standing on his front step just staring, wide-eyed, like he couldn't quite believe what was walking down his street.

Nobody asked us questions yet. They just started doing things — wrapping blankets around shoulders, pressing cups of something warm into shaking hands, guiding the worst-off toward cars that would ferry them ahead to wherever the doctor was waiting. It was the strangest welcome I'd ever

gotten anywhere, and also, somehow, without anyone saying a single formal word of it, the warmest.

“Nearly there,” Hugh said one last time, and this time, finally, he was right.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Eleven: The Village Hall

We spent that first night in the village community hall, the same one that usually hosted boring town meetings, now packed with camp beds and about a thousand blankets that seemed to appear out of nowhere, carried in by women I'd never met, unloaded from car trunks and even a kid's wagon.

The nearest hospital had already filled up with the worst injuries, taken there by helicopter, so the rest of us — the walking-wounded, the shaken-but-okay — stayed in Thornfield Beck, looked after by a retired doctor named Dr. Okonkwo-Bell who moved between cots with a flashlight strapped to her head and a calm voice that somehow held the whole room together.

I had a mild concussion and needed four stitches above my eyebrow, which I watched happen in a little mirror, more fascinated than scared, while my mom held my other hand so tight it kind of hurt. Dr. Okonkwo-Bell talked me through every single step before she did it, which nobody at any hospital had ever bothered to do before, explaining exactly what the needle would feel like and exactly how many stitches she thought it would take, like she trusted an eleven-year-old to handle the truth better than a vague, softened version of it.

The hall itself was this plain brick building with wood floors that creaked under about a hundred pairs of feet, folding tables usually set up for bake sales now shoved against the walls to make room for camp beds, and a big paper banner still taped up from some earlier event that said HAPPY RETIREMENT BARRY in wobbly letters, which felt so unbelievably out of place that I actually laughed a little the first time I noticed it, and then felt bad for laughing.

By Lynden Pennington

The village had gotten organized incredibly fast — like they'd done this before, or like the knowledge of how to do it was just sitting there in everybody's bones, waiting. A man named Frank who ran the village shop opened it at midnight and gave away basically everything on his shelves without anybody even having to ask. A woman named Sheila, who ran the pub down the lane, made tea in a pot so huge it looked like something from a fairy tale and carried cup after cup to strangers who couldn't stop shaking. Sheila was maybe fifty, built solid, with bright red hair scraped back in a bun that was clearly losing a losing battle by hour three, and a voice that carried across the whole hall without her ever seeming to raise it — the kind of voice that just naturally made people listen. She barked orders at grown men twice her size like she'd been running that pub, and probably that whole village, her entire life, which, it turned out later, she basically had.

"You'll take tea," she told my mom, setting a cup down without asking. "Sweet. You're in shock, love, whether you feel it yet or not."

My mom drank the tea. She told me later it was, against every reasonable expectation of that entire day, the best thing she had ever tasted.

Sheila didn't stop moving the whole night — checking on people, refilling cups, snapping at a teenage volunteer to fetch more blankets from her own upstairs closet, muttering the whole time like she was annoyed, except her hands were always gentle whenever she actually touched somebody, which told me the muttering was mostly just how she covered up caring so much it probably scared her a little.

Near dawn, I watched my mom find her phone — screen cracked, battery almost dead, somehow still working — and type out a message to my grandma, the one she'd promised to send the second our wheels touched down. The wheels had touched down, all right. Just not the way anybody had promised.

By Lynden Pennington

We crashed. We're alive. Milo is alive. I'm okay. I love you.

I read it over her shoulder and didn't say anything. There wasn't really anything else that sentence needed.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Twelve: The Names

On the third day, the village held a gathering at the small stone church — not a funeral exactly, because a lot of people hadn't even been officially identified yet, but something the vicar, a quiet young guy named Reverend Payne, just called "a remembering."

The church itself was tiny, older than anything I'd ever stood inside back home, with thick stone walls and narrow stained-glass windows that threw little patches of colored light across the pews — red and blue and gold, moving slowly across the floor as the sun came up outside. It smelled like candle wax and old wood and something else I couldn't name, something that felt like history, like generations of people had sat in those same pews carrying their own griefs long before we ever showed up carrying ours.

Ninety-five people from our flight hadn't made it out of that field. I hadn't known any of their names before the crash, but I started learning some of them there in the church, in pieces — an old couple who'd been married over fifty years, sitting together right until the end. A guy on his way to a job interview. A woman flying home to her husband. A teenager visiting a grandmother she'd never met in person. Reverend Payne read each name out loud, slow, pausing after every single one like he wanted to give the room enough time to actually hold it before moving to the next, and by about the twentieth name, I noticed people all around me weren't even bothering to wipe their tears away anymore. They just let them fall.

I sat very still through the whole thing, the same kind of still I'd had since the crash — the kind that isn't really calm, more like holding your breath and not quite remembering how to let it out. My mom sat beside me with

one hand resting on my knee the entire time, not squeezing, not moving, just there, like an anchor.

Afterward, walking back along the lane through the village, I finally said something to my mom.

“The little kid. The one I sat with in the field. His name is Theo.”

“I didn’t know that.”

“He told me on the second day. His mom’s name is Yasmin. They were flying to see his dad, who’s in the army. I don’t know if his dad’s even still alive, because of the war. Nobody knows anything right now.”

My mom crouched down in front of me, ignoring how much that probably hurt her bruised ribs, and took my face in both hands. “You did a brave thing, sitting with him.”

“It didn’t feel brave. It just felt like the only thing to do.”

“That’s what brave usually feels like,” she said, and I could tell she meant it more than she’d ever meant almost anything.

We walked the rest of the way back in quiet, past a stone wall covered in moss, past a war memorial from about a hundred years ago listing forty names from a village small enough that everybody on that old list had probably been somebody’s brother, somebody’s son. I stopped and read a few of the names on my own, running my finger along the cold, carved letters, wondering what those forty people would think if they knew a plane full of strangers had fallen into their fields a hundred years later and been taken in exactly the same way their own village had probably once taken in soldiers coming home, or refugees passing through, or anybody else who’d ever needed somewhere safe to land.

By Lynden Pennington

I was starting to understand something about Thornfield Beck, even that early on — that it was a place that had buried its own people before, a long time ago, and somehow knew how to make room for grief without letting it take over everything else. It didn't make the grief smaller. It just gave it somewhere to sit that wasn't right on top of everything else, and I think that's a harder trick than it sounds like, and I think that village had been quietly practicing it for a very long time.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Thirteen: Nowhere to Go

By the end of the first week, the real shape of our situation had become clear, and honestly, it was worse than the crash itself in its own quiet way. The crash had been sudden and violent and over fast. This was slower, and somehow that made it harder — every day another door quietly closing somewhere far away, and us just sitting in a borrowed community hall watching it happen on secondhand news and half-charged phones.

Switzerland wasn't reachable anymore — no flights, half of Europe's airspace closed because everybody was too scared of what might be flying through it. Aunt Renata called constantly, first just relieved we were alive, and then scared all over again about what to do next, her voice getting thinner and more frantic each time the connection dropped and had to be redialed.

Going back to New York seemed even worse. The news that made it to Thornfield Beck described a city under curfew, its airport barely working, buildings I used to walk past every day now sitting near actual military equipment. My mom watched a clip on Frank's shop television one afternoon of a street she recognized, two blocks from our old apartment, and I saw her hand go still on the counter, gripping it a little too hard, and I understood without her saying anything that whatever she was seeing didn't look like the street either of us remembered.

My mom's boss wrote her an email that said something like: *You can't go home right now, Clare, because there isn't really a home to go back to that's safe. Stay wherever you've landed.*

She read that line about six times. I watched her read it. And I watched something settle in her face — not happiness, exactly, but a kind of

decision, the way her whole body seemed to loosen just slightly, like she'd been holding her breath for a week without realizing it and had finally let some of it out.

She went to talk to Reverend Payne about it, mostly because she didn't know who else to ask, and before she'd even finished explaining, he said, "We've got a cottage. Belonged to old Mrs. Tavistock — she's in a care home now, and her nephew hasn't been able to sell it. Wants airing out, but it's got a roof, and it's yours as long as you need it. Rent's whatever you can manage. Nobody in this village is going to charge a fair price to a woman and her son who fell out of the sky into our sheep pasture."

My mom cried when he said that — I wasn't there, but she told me about it later, and about how Reverend Payne just kept sorting a box of donated sweaters while she cried, not making it weird, just letting her have the moment, occasionally holding up a particularly ugly cardigan for her to see, until she was laughing through the tears instead of just crying through them.

"Don't thank me," he told her. "Thank Mrs. Tavistock. Thank Hugh, for finding you. We didn't do anything remarkable here. We just did what you do."

My mom told me that sentence stuck with her for a long time after that — *what you do*. Like kindness wasn't some special extra thing some people had and some didn't. Like it was just supposed to be normal. Like the war hadn't managed to convince this one small village otherwise. She told me later she'd walked out of that church office already thinking of it, without quite realizing it yet, as the beginning of something instead of just the end of everything else.

By Lynden Pennington

She came home that afternoon and told me about the cottage, and about Reverend Payne, and about the cardigans, and I remember thinking, even at eleven, that something in her voice had changed — steadier, somehow, like a person setting down a heavy bag she'd been carrying without realizing how much her arms had been aching.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Fourteen: Mrs. Tavistock's Cottage

The cottage sat at the end of a short lane called Beck Row, two doors down from the pub, close enough that I could hear people laughing through the wall some nights. It was made of the same gray stone as half the other buildings in the village, with a slate roof that turned almost silver when it rained, which, this being the north of England, was often. It had two bedrooms, a kitchen with an old stove that took my mom a full week to figure out and that I understood, annoyingly, on my very first try, low ceilings my mom kept bumping her head on until she finally memorized where the beams were, and a back garden completely overgrown with roses that Sheila said Mrs. Tavistock used to keep "in the kind of order that would shame an army." They'd gone wild in her absence, climbing up over an old wooden trellis and along most of the back wall, red and pink and this one stubborn white one that grew crooked no matter how many times somebody tried to train it straight.

We showed up with basically nothing — one donated bag each, clothes that didn't quite fit, all of it warm anyway. I remember my mom sitting on the floor of an empty, cold bedroom, just staring at the wall for a while, and I understood, even at eleven, that she was grieving all the small stuff that couldn't be replaced by any donation box — her old photos, the smell of our old kitchen, things too small to explain to anyone but too big to just let go of.

I started at the village school about two weeks in — one building, forty-one kids total, ages five to eleven, run by a no-nonsense teacher named Mrs. Renwick who basically decided on day one that I wasn't going to fall behind, war or no war, crash or no crash.

By Lynden Pennington

Theo — the kid from the field — turned out to live four farms over, and pretty fast, the two of us became basically inseparable. Theo was the kind of kid who narrated everything he did out loud, like a little sports announcer for his own life — "and now Theo climbs the fence, incredible technique" — and who was scared of literally nothing except spiders, which was funny given he lived on an actual farm crawling with them. We disappeared after school into the hills most days with Hugh's border collie, coming home muddy and, for a few hours at a time, completely and gloriously normal.

News about Theo's dad came about three weeks in — alive, hurt, but stable, in a hospital that couldn't say yet when he'd come home. Theo's mom, Yasmin, cried so hard with relief she had to sit down right there in the shop, and honestly, the whole village felt that news like it was their own. That was something I noticed a lot about Thornfield Beck — nobody dealt with anything alone. Everything got carried together, out loud, in the shop, over the counter, which somehow made even the scary stuff a little more bearable.

Frank, who ran that shop, was this small, wiry man who never seemed to stop moving, restocking shelves and chatting with every single person who came through the door like he'd been waiting all day just to talk to them specifically. He always smelled a little like the cinnamon sweets he sold by the register, and he had a habit of sneaking me one for free every time my mom wasn't looking, then pretending very seriously that he hadn't.

My mom started helping out too — a few mornings a week at the shop, and eventually helping Dr. Okonkwo-Bell organize supplies for other displaced families in the area, work that made her feel, for the first time since the crash, like she was standing on solid ground again.

Some nights, lying in the cold cottage with the roses gone quiet outside my window, I'd try to figure out exactly where the old life ended and this new

one started. I never could find the exact line. There just wasn't one. There was only a field, and then a village, and a kid who used to be from New York slowly becoming, somehow, also from somewhere else. I'd fall asleep most nights listening to the pub's laughter through the wall, and it stopped sounding like a stranger's noise, and started sounding, slowly, like something closer to home.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Fifteen: New Faces

My first real day at the village school, I got there early because my mom was nervous and nervous moms make you early for everything. The building itself was smaller than my old school's cafeteria back in New York — one long stone room split into two sections by a folding partition, one side for the little kids, one side for the rest of us, all forty-one students total, which was fewer kids than had been in my old fifth-grade class alone.

There was a corkboard by the entrance covered in local notices, and pinned right in the middle of it, alongside the lost-and-found list and a flyer for the harvest festival, was a printed sheet about fuel rationing and a list of names — village boys, a few of them barely older than the sixth-formers — serving somewhere overseas. Nobody made a big deal of it. It was just there, the way the war was just there most days, folded quietly into the ordinary business of a school morning.

Mrs. Renwick met me at the door like she'd been standing there waiting specifically for me, which, it turned out, she basically had. She was tall and sharp-featured, with reading glasses permanently pushed up into gray hair that never seemed to move no matter what she was doing, and a voice that could go from gentle to absolutely no-nonsense in the space of half a sentence.

"You'll sit here," she said, pointing to a desk near the window, "next to Theo, since I understand you two are already acquainted. And you'll not fall behind just because your circumstances have been extraordinary, Mr. Whitfield. Extraordinary circumstances are no excuse for ordinary laziness."

By Lynden Pennington

I liked her immediately, in the way you like a teacher who clearly isn't going to treat you like you're made of glass.

The other kids were curious about me in the way kids are curious about anything new — not unkind, just staring a little too long, whispering a little too loud. A girl named Poppy, who I later learned ran faster than every boy in the school including some of the older ones, asked me straight out at lunch whether it was true a plane had actually fallen out of the sky, like it was the coolest thing she'd ever heard instead of the worst thing that had ever happened to me.

"Yeah," I said. "It's true."

"Was it scary?"

Nobody had asked me that so directly before. Grown-ups tended to tiptoe around the question, using softer words, checking my face for signs I might fall apart. Poppy just asked it straight, the way kids do, and somehow that made it easier to answer honestly.

"Yeah," I said. "It was really scary."

She nodded like that settled something for her, then went right back to eating her sandwich and telling me about the time she beat her older brother in a footrace across three whole fields, and I understood, watching her, that this was maybe the first completely normal conversation I'd had with another kid since the crash — not careful, not gentle, just two kids talking, and it felt like breathing after being underwater.

Not everything about that first week was easy, though. There was a boy named Callum, a year older than me, who made a point of asking loudly, in front of everybody, whether I'd cried during the crash, in a tone that made it pretty clear he was hoping the answer was yes and hoping to make me feel small about it either way. I didn't answer him. Theo, standing next to

me, answered instead, flat and unbothered, “Everybody would’ve cried, you absolute muppet,” which made half the class laugh and made Callum go red and quiet for the rest of the day. I decided right then that I liked having Theo around for more reasons than just the field.

Mrs. Renwick, for her part, didn’t let the awkward moments slide by unnoticed either. She had a way of catching exactly the right amount of attention on exactly the right kid at exactly the right moment, redirecting Callum’s energy into a math problem on the board before he could say anything else, without ever making it feel like a punishment, just a fact of how her classroom worked.

By the end of that first week, I’d mostly stopped being the new kid who fell out of the sky and started just being the new kid, period, which might not sound like much of an upgrade, but honestly, it was everything.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Sixteen: The Letter I Didn't Send

About a month in, I tried writing Deshawn a letter. An actual paper letter, because I didn't have his new number yet and the internet in the cottage was spotty at best, and because there was something about writing it out by hand that felt like it mattered more than typing it would have.

I sat at the kitchen table one evening with a pad of paper Frank had given me from the shop and started writing, and then immediately didn't know what to say. How do you explain any of this to somebody back home? Where do you even start?

Dear Deshawn, I wrote. *You are not going to believe what happened.*

I got about a paragraph in — the crash, the field, Hugh finding us — before I stopped, because writing it down made it feel real in a different way than just remembering it did, more solid, more permanent, like putting it on paper was somehow making it official.

I tried again a few days later. This time I skipped the crash completely and just wrote about the village instead — Theo, the chess set, the sheep, Sheila's tea, the weird cinnamon sweets Frank kept sneaking me. It felt easier to write about the good parts. It also felt, weirdly, a little bit like betraying the hard parts, like if I only told him about the nice stuff, I was pretending the rest hadn't happened.

I never finished either letter. I kept them both in the drawer of my new desk, under some school papers, for months, not sure what I was even keeping them for.

My mom found them once, doing laundry, and asked me gently if I wanted to send them.

By Lynden Pennington

“They’re not done,” I told her.

“They don’t have to be done. Sometimes you just send what you have.”

I thought about that for a long time, but I still didn’t send them. I think, looking back, I wasn’t ready yet — not to explain it to Deshawn, and maybe not even fully to explain it to myself. Some things you have to sit with a while before you can hand them to somebody else, even somebody you trust completely.

It would be more than a year before Deshawn and I actually spoke again, and when we did, it wasn’t because of anything I wrote. It just happened on its own, the way the most important things sometimes do, right when you’ve almost stopped waiting for them.

I still have those two unfinished letters somewhere, tucked in a box with the chess knight and the old skateboard wheel. I like having them. They’re proof of a version of myself that was still trying to figure out how to say any of this out loud, back before I knew how.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Seventeen: Hugh's Boy

It was Sheila who finally told me about Hugh's son, one slow evening at the pub while my mom was getting us dinner. I was sitting at the end of the bar swinging my legs off the tall stool, and Sheila must have decided I was old enough, or maybe just needed to know, because she leaned in close and lowered her voice the way people do when they're about to say something they don't say often.

"Hugh had a boy," she said, wiping down the bar in that unhurried way she did everything. "Daniel. Would be near forty now. Died a long way from here, going on eighteen years back, in a different war than this one. Hugh doesn't talk about it, not ever. But he's had you up at that farm nearly every day since the crash, love, and I've not seen that man look so easy in his own skin in a decade."

I thought about Hugh's face in the field that first morning — how gray it had gone — and understood it a little differently after that. Not just shock at a plane falling into his pasture. Something older underneath it too, some door he'd kept shut for eighteen years that a falling plane had somehow, without meaning to, cracked open just slightly.

I found him a few days later mending a stretch of stone wall at the edge of the field, near where the wreckage used to be before it got cleared away. A small radio sat propped on a fence post nearby, tuned low to the news, the same tired voice reading out territory changes and casualty figures that had become the background music of practically every adult conversation that autumn. Hugh never turned it off, but he never seemed to really listen to it either — just let it run, the way you'd let weather happen around you. I'd been going up most afternoons, handing him stones while he explained how

to stack them so they wouldn't fall — bigger stones on the bottom, smaller ones wedged in the gaps, every piece supporting the ones above it, no mortar, nothing holding it together except the stones themselves knowing exactly how to lean on each other.

"You're a good hand at this," he told me. "Careful. Don't rush a stone before it's ready to sit."

I didn't say anything about what Sheila had told me. I don't know if he knew that I knew, but something in how he talked to me changed slightly after that afternoon anyway — a little more, not exactly softer, but steadier, like he'd decided I could be trusted with something and wasn't going to make a big deal out of deciding it.

My mom told me later that she'd talked to him about Daniel too, and that he'd said something to her I still think about: "He's not Daniel. I know that. But there's a use in it anyway — him needing somewhere to put his hands while his head sorts itself out. Me having wall that wants mending and nobody left to help mend it. Doesn't have to mean more than that. Doesn't have to mean less, either."

I didn't know all that at the time. What I knew was that stacking stones with Hugh, most afternoons, was the only time my brain actually went quiet. Not thinking about the crash, or the names, or any of it. Just stone, next stone, next stone, the sound of them settling into place, Hugh's slow steady breathing beside me, his dog dozing in the grass nearby with one ear always half-cocked toward the road.

Turns out that's its own kind of medicine. Nobody ever explains that to you. You just have to find it by accident, like I did.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Eighteen: What Comes Back at Night

The nightmares started around six weeks in. Dr. Okonkwo-Bell told my mom that was actually pretty normal — that your brain sometimes waits until it feels safe enough to finally deal with the scary stuff it couldn't afford to deal with in the moment.

Knowing that didn't make it any easier when I woke up at 2 a.m., sometimes 3, with this sound coming out of me that wasn't quite screaming and wasn't quite crying, my sheets tangled around my legs like I'd been trying to run somewhere in my sleep. My mom came every single time. I'd hear her door first, then her feet in the hallway, quick but careful, like she was trying not to wake a house that was already awake. She never turned the big light on, just the little lamp by my bed, soft enough that the room didn't feel like it was suddenly interrogating me. She'd sit on the edge of my bed and just be there, not saying anything at first, until my breathing slowed back down enough that I could actually hear hers too, steady, right next to me, like something I could hold onto with my ears instead of my hands.

Sometimes I'd tell her pieces of it — the green rushing up, the sound of metal tearing. Sometimes I wouldn't say anything at all, just breathe, and let her hold on, her arms around me and my knees pulled up to my chest the way I used to sit when I was little and scared of the dark, except this wasn't the dark I was scared of anymore.

One night — I remember this one especially, because it was the worst one — I couldn't stop shaking for a long time after I woke up, even with her right there, and she didn't try to make me stop. She just kept her hand moving slow across my back, the same three or four inches over and over, not

saying anything, until the rain against the old windows became the loudest thing in the room and my shaking finally wound down into something quieter.

“Am I broken?” I asked her, into the dark, really quiet.

She didn’t answer right away. I remember that — the pause before she spoke, like she wanted to get the words exactly right instead of just saying the first easy thing that came to mind.

“No,” she said, finally, and she said it like she meant it completely, even though I think some part of her wasn’t totally sure. “You’re hurt. Those are different things. A broken thing doesn’t come back. A hurt thing does. It just takes the time it takes.”

“I keep thinking about the people who didn’t get up,” I told her. “Why did we get up? Why not them?”

There’s no good answer to a question like that. My mom didn’t pretend there was one. She just sat with it for a second, and I could feel her thinking, really thinking, not just reaching for something comforting to say.

“I don’t know,” she said. “I ask myself that same thing almost every night. I don’t think there’s an answer that makes it make sense. But I know this — you got up, and you sat with Theo when he was scared, and you’ve been kind to people this whole time, even while you were scared too. Whatever the reason was or wasn’t, that’s what you did with it. That’s not nothing. Maybe that’s the only answer there actually is.”

I didn’t say anything back for a while. I just leaned into her, and she let me, the rain still going outside, the little lamp still on, both of us awake in the middle of the night in a house that used to belong to a stranger and somehow, slowly, was starting to feel like ours.

By Lynden Pennington

“Will the dreams stop?” I finally asked.

“I think they get further apart,” she said. “I think one day you’ll notice it’s been a whole month since the last one. I don’t think it goes away all at once. I think it just gets quieter.”

She stayed until I fell back asleep, like she did most nights that whole winter. I found out later she’d sit in the hallway afterward for a long time, alone, doing her own math about her own guilt in the quiet, before finally going back to bed herself. I didn’t know that back then. I know it now, and it makes me love her even more than I already did, if that’s even possible.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Nineteen: The Harvest Festival

By late October, we'd been in Thornfield Beck a little over two months, and the village had started to feel less like a shelter and more like a place we actually lived. I'd stopped noticing the smell of the cottage as somebody else's smell. I'd stopped flinching, mostly, every time I heard a loud engine overhead.

The harvest festival was, according to Sheila, "older than the church roof, and that roof's older than sense." It took over the same community hall that used to be full of camp beds and blankets, now piled instead with pies and vegetables shaped like little monsters that all the kids thought were hilarious — a carrot that looked exactly like it was screaming, a potato with what everybody agreed was definitely a face — and a cake contest Mrs. Renwick took way more seriously than seemed reasonable, walking the judging table with a clipboard like she was inspecting a crime scene. There was less sugar in everything than there would have been in a normal year, on account of the shortages, and less butter too, but nobody seemed to mind or even really mention it — just one more small adjustment the war had folded quietly into everyday life, the way it had folded itself into so many other ordinary things by then.

I entered a chess tournament that Frank had organized with a ton of fanfare, hand-drawn brackets taped up on the wall like it was a real championship. I still think what happened next was on purpose even though he never admitted it — I made it all the way to the final and beat him, in front of like thirty cheering villagers, most of whom didn't know the first thing about chess but cheered anyway every time somebody moved a piece with any kind of dramatic flair. My mom said I glowed for the rest of the night. I think she's right.

By Lynden Pennington

Theo won a pie-eating contest and threw up behind the hall ten minutes later, which made both of us laugh so hard I forgot, for a second, that I even had healing ribs. Sheila made him drink water afterward and called him “an absolute disgrace and I’m dead proud of you,” which about summed up how the whole village treated both of us most days.

Near the end of the night, Reverend Payne climbed up on a chair and gave a short speech I still remember almost word for word.

“We’ve had a strange year,” he said, and everybody laughed. “We’ve had a plane land in Hugh’s south pasture, which I don’t believe is in the parish records anywhere. We’ve had new neighbors arrive in about the worst possible way a person can arrive, and I’ll tell you — watching this village take them in has been the finest thing I’ve seen in eleven years behind this pulpit. There’s a war out there, and none of us can pretend otherwise. But I’ll say this — it hasn’t taken this.” He waved at the whole hall, the pies, the kids chasing each other around chair legs. “It hasn’t taken this yet, and I don’t intend to let it, not while there’s tea left in the pot.”

Everybody clapped. Hugh, standing near the back with his cap in his hands, clapped longer than anybody else, and I noticed my mom noticing that too.

I leaned into my mom’s shoulder, the way I used to when I was little, before the war, before any of this, and she put her arm around me, and I remember thinking: this isn’t the life we were supposed to have. And then, right behind that thought, another one showed up that surprised me: but it might actually be a good one anyway.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Twenty: The Storm

Theo and I got caught out on the hills once, that first winter, in a storm that came in so fast neither of us saw it coming until it was already on top of us.

We'd gone up past Hugh's far pasture chasing his dog, who'd taken off after a rabbit and refused to come back no matter how much we yelled, and by the time we finally caught up with her — sitting there panting, looking extremely pleased with herself, no rabbit in sight — the sky had gone from gray to a strange greenish black in a way that even I, a kid who'd grown up watching weather apps, knew probably wasn't good.

"We should go back," Theo said, already turning, and that's when the wind hit, hard and sudden, and then the rain, sideways, so cold it felt like being hit with tiny needles.

We ran. I don't remember most of it clearly — just running, and the dog barking, and Theo yelling something I couldn't hear over the wind, and the ground turning to mud under my shoes so fast I nearly went down twice, my heart pounding in a way that felt uncomfortably close to how it had pounded on the plane, which I noticed even in the middle of everything and hated noticing.

We found shelter, eventually, in a half-collapsed old stone shed that smelled like sheep and hay, and we huddled there together with the dog pressed between us for warmth, watching the storm rage outside, both of us soaked completely through and shaking.

"My dad used to say storms up here come out of nowhere because the hills don't warn you," Theo said, teeth chattering. "One minute it's fine. Next minute it's not."

By Lynden Pennington

I thought about the plane. I didn't say anything, but Theo must have seen something in my face, because he didn't say anything else about storms coming out of nowhere either. We just sat there, quiet, until it passed, listening to the rain hammer against the old stone roof, both of us leaning a little closer to the dog, and to each other, without either of us saying why.

Hugh found us about forty minutes later, storming up the hillside himself with two extra coats and a face like thunder that had nothing to do with the weather.

"You two had me half out of my mind," he said, which from Hugh was basically a full-blown emotional breakdown. He wrapped us both in the coats without another word and marched us back down to the farmhouse, where his kitchen was warm and smelled like the stew he'd apparently abandoned mid-cooking to come find us.

He didn't lecture us, exactly. He just sat us down at his table, put bowls of that stew in front of us, and said, quietly, once, "You gave me a fright." Which, coming from a man who'd once run straight at a burning plane wreck without hesitating, told me more about how scared he'd actually been than any lecture could have.

I never told my mom the full details of that afternoon. But I noticed, after that, that Hugh started keeping two extra coats by his back door, just in case, and I understood it wasn't really about the weather anymore. It was about him having already lost one boy to something sudden and out of his control, and never wanting to feel that particular fear again if he could help it.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Twenty-One: News From Home

A letter from Aaron, my mom's old boss, finally caught up to us in November, and I knew something was wrong the second she opened it, just by how careful and quiet she got, the envelope shaking slightly in her hands even before she'd read a single word.

He wrote that our old building had gotten damaged in an attack a couple weeks after we left. Not totally destroyed, but bad enough that the top two floors — ours included — got condemned. He'd gone to look at it once things calmed down a little, stood across the street staring up at the blown-out windows of the apartment where I'd once cooked my mom a birthday dinner that involved way too much garlic. He couldn't even go inside. Nobody could.

I'm sorry, Clare, he wrote. *I know it's just an apartment. I know you and Milo are what actually matter, and you're both alive, and that's the real math that counts. But I also know that's not really how grief works, and you're allowed to be sad about the rest of it too.*

My mom cried about it that night, quietly, into a dish towel so I wouldn't hear, though I heard anyway, through the thin cottage wall between our two rooms. I lay in bed listening and didn't go to her, not right away, because some part of me understood she needed a minute to have that grief alone before she folded it back up and became the steady version of herself again for my sake.

I understood, even then, that it wasn't really about the apartment. It was about the kitchen where she used to scramble eggs. The fire escape where Deshawn hugged me goodbye. The creaky fourth stair I'd never again forget to skip. A whole life that existed now only in our heads, gone the way the

roses out back went dormant every winter — except roses come back. Some things don't.

She told me the next morning, over eggs, same as always, and I took it the way I'd been taking most things by then — carefully, seriously, like I was solving a problem.

"Is Deshawn okay?" I asked first, because somewhere in the last few months, that had become the thing I cared about most — not stuff, but people.

"I don't know yet, baby. I'm trying to find out."

I sat with that for a while, turning my fork over in my eggs, watching the yolk go cold and not really caring.

"I don't think I want to go back," I said finally. "Even if we could. I miss it. I miss Deshawn and the fire escape. But I don't want to go back to it. Is that bad?"

"No," my mom said, and I could tell she meant it completely. "That's not bad at all. I think it just means home turned into two things instead of one. You're allowed to miss one of them and still be glad you found the other."

I thought about that a lot in the days after, turning it over the same way I turned over the fork in my eggs — the idea that a person could carry two homes at once, and that neither one canceled the other out, and that maybe grief and gratitude really were just two rooms in the same house, and you were allowed to walk between them as many times a day as you needed to.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Twenty-Two: The Kid Who Wasn't Welcome

Not everybody in Thornfield Beck was thrilled about us staying, and I found that out the hard way, about three months in, from a woman named Mrs. Pruitt who ran the flower stall outside the church on Sundays.

I'd been sent to buy flowers for Dr. Okonkwo-Bell's birthday, a task my mom had entrusted me with very seriously, and when I handed over my money, Mrs. Pruitt looked at me for a long moment before taking it.

"You're the crash boy," she said. Not unkindly, exactly, but not warmly either.

"I guess so," I said.

"My nephew's a fireman down in Alnhaven. Says the roads have been a nightmare since your lot arrived — ambulances, relief trucks, all sorts. Council's spending money on temporary housing that could've gone toward the school roof, which has needed fixing longer than you've been alive." She handed me the flowers, sharp and quick. "Not your fault, I suppose. Just saying."

I walked home with the flowers feeling something I hadn't quite felt since we'd arrived — like maybe not everybody saw us the way Sheila and Hugh and Frank did. Like maybe, to some people, we were just a complication that had fallen out of the sky and landed expensive.

I told my mom about it that night, expecting her to get angry on my behalf, which she sort of did, briefly, before her face settled into something more thoughtful.

By Lynden Pennington

“She’s not wrong that it’s cost something,” my mom said. “Taking in ninety-one strangers costs a village something real, even when the village decides it’s worth it. I think most people here decided that. I don’t think everybody has to feel exactly the same way for that decision to still be the right one.”

I didn’t love that answer at the time. I wanted her to just say Mrs. Pruitt was wrong and mean and leave it at that. But over the next few weeks, I noticed my mom doing something I hadn’t expected — going out of her way to help at the school fundraiser for that broken roof, organizing a donation drive through the little clinic network she worked with, quietly directing some of the outside relief money that had come in for crash survivors toward general village repairs instead, once our own immediate needs were covered.

I asked her about it once, and she just shrugged. “It’s not about proving Mrs. Pruitt wrong specifically. It’s about making sure this doesn’t feel like a one-way street to anybody, even the people who weren’t sure about us to begin with. Kindness works better when it doesn’t feel like it’s owed.”

By spring, the school roof got fixed — partly from village fundraising, partly, I found out much later, from money my mom had quietly helped route there. Mrs. Pruitt never apologized, exactly. But the next time I bought flowers from her, she threw in an extra one for free and told me to tell my mother “the roof looks a sight better now,” which from her, I was starting to understand, was about as close to a thank-you as she got.

I think that was its own kind of lesson, one I hadn’t expected the village to teach me — that not every hard feeling needs to be fixed or forgiven all at once. Sometimes it just needs time, and a little bit of quiet effort from people who’d rather build something than argue about it.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Twenty-Three: Blackout

The war got closer to Thornfield Beck in December, though it never actually arrived — something I'd be grateful for a long time without ever quite losing the fear underneath it.

A military supply site outside the nearest town got hit one night, close enough that we felt the shake in our chests all the way from the village, plates rattling in Sheila's kitchen cupboards, the windows in our cottage buzzing faintly in their old frames. Reverend Payne rang the church bell in a pattern nobody under about eighty had heard before — the old air-raid signal, apparently, passed down without anyone quite remembering how they'd learned it, the way some songs get stuck in a family for generations without anybody remembering who taught them first.

We spent that night crammed into the cellar under the pub with about two dozen other villagers, candlelight throwing huge shadows up the whitewashed walls between the beer casks. I sat against my mom's side, shaking, not crying, just shaking, and she held on to me and said, "It's not the plane. It's not the same thing happening again."

"I know," I said, in a voice that made it pretty obvious that knowing and actually believing were two totally different things.

Hugh sat across the cellar with his dog's head on his knee, and he caught my mom's eye once through the candlelight and just nodded, slow, like he understood exactly what this felt like from some other war, a long time ago. Sheila sat near the stairs handing out mugs of something warm to anybody who looked like they needed it, which was pretty much everybody, her usual bustling energy turned down into something quieter, more careful, like even she understood this wasn't a night for bossing anybody around.

By Lynden Pennington

The all-clear came a little after 3 a.m. — a different bell pattern this time, Sheila said it meant “still here” in the old code — and we all climbed out into the cold night together and, without really discussing it, walked straight to the church, not for any service, just because it was warm and open, and being together felt safer than being alone, even with the danger already passed. I remember the sky that night, unbelievably full of stars, more than I’d ever seen back in New York, and the far northern horizon still glowing a faint dull red where the depot fire hadn’t quite burned itself out.

I fell asleep against my mom’s shoulder in a pew, and when I woke up a little, I looked around at everybody there in the dim light — Frank making tea on a camp stove someone had produced from nowhere,
Dr. Okonkwo-Bell checking on an old man who’d had a scare, Reverend Payne moving between pews making sure everyone was okay — and I understood something I don’t think I could have explained back then, but I can now: being safe never really had that much to do with geography. Switzerland had promised mountains between us and the war. Thornfield Beck gave us something the mountains never could — people who would sit next to you in a cellar and hold the whole night together until it passed.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Twenty-Four: Christmas at Thornfield Beck

I didn't think I wanted a Christmas that year. It felt wrong somehow, like celebrating anything while half the world was still figuring out how to stop fighting, while my old building sat boarded up an ocean away, while ninety-five people who should have been having their own Christmas somewhere weren't going to get one at all.

My mom must have felt something similar, because neither of us brought it up until Sheila did, about a week before, setting down a cup of tea in front of my mom at the pub and saying, without any question mark in her voice at all, "You'll come to the village Christmas, both of you. No arguments."

We went. I almost didn't want to admit how glad I was that we did.

The whole village turned out for it, packed into the same community hall that had once been a triage ward, now strung with lights and paper chains the little kids had made at school, a tree in the corner decorated with a chaotic mix of proper ornaments and homemade ones, including, I noticed, a slightly lopsided paper snowflake I was pretty sure Theo had made and was way too proud of.

There was a gift exchange, the kind where everybody brings something small and it gets swapped around, and I ended up with a hand-carved wooden fox from an old man I'd barely spoken to before, who told me gruffly that he'd carved it himself and that foxes were clever animals who knew how to survive just about anything, which felt like it meant more than he probably intended it to.

By Lynden Pennington

Frank gave out free cinnamon sweets to every kid in the hall, obviously, and Hugh showed up in an actual sweater instead of his usual wax jacket, which Sheila announced loudly was “a Christmas miracle in itself,” making him go red all the way to his ears.

At one point, Reverend Payne stood up and said a few quiet words — not a big speech, just a thank-you, for the village showing up for each other again this year, same as every year, war or no war. Then somebody started singing, badly, off-key, and everybody else joined in just as badly, and it turned into this huge, warm, terrible-sounding chorus that I will remember, I think, for the rest of my life.

My mom cried a little, quietly, in the middle of all that noise, and when I looked at her, worried, she just shook her head and said, “Good tears, baby. I promise. Good tears.”

I believed her. Standing in that hall, surrounded by people who’d been strangers barely three months earlier, holding a wooden fox in my hand and singing off-key with everybody else, I understood something about home I hadn’t understood before — that it isn’t always the place you started. Sometimes it’s just the place that shows up for you when you need it most, decorations and all.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Twenty-Five: Birthday in the Hills

My twelfth birthday came about five months after the crash, and I almost didn't want to mention it to anybody, because it felt strange to celebrate anything so soon after everything, like blowing out candles might somehow be disrespectful to the ninety-five people who wouldn't get any more birthdays at all.

My mom noticed the date on the calendar before I said a word about it, because of course she did, and she didn't ask permission, just started quietly planning something, which I only found out about because Theo was a terrible secret-keeper and let it slip four days early.

"You're not supposed to know," he said, the second the words left his mouth, horrified at himself.

"Know what?"

"Nothing. Forget I said anything." He lasted about eleven more seconds. "It's a surprise party. At Hugh's farm. Don't tell your mom I told you."

I didn't tell her. I pretended to be shocked on the actual day, walking up to Hugh's farmhouse for what I claimed to believe was just an ordinary Saturday visit, and found half the village crammed into his kitchen and spilling out into the yard, bunting strung between fence posts, Sheila's famous sweet tea in a pot the size of a small barrel. Somebody had the wireless on low in the next room, tuned to the evening news out of habit more than anything, a voice reading out the names of towns none of us had heard of a year earlier, and Hugh reached over at one point, without breaking conversation, and simply switched it off, the way you'd shoo away a wasp at a picnic — not ignoring the war exactly, just deciding, for one afternoon, that it wasn't allowed at my birthday.

By Lynden Pennington

Frank had baked a cake himself, which turned out to be a mistake he cheerfully owned up to — it came out slightly burnt on one side, and he'd tried to fix it by carving the burnt part into what he insisted was "artistic detailing," which mostly just looked like a cake with a chunk missing. It was, somehow, one of the best cakes I've ever eaten.

Hugh gave me a small carved wooden chess piece, a second knight, to go with mine. "Every knight needs a partner," he said, gruff, not quite meeting my eyes, which was as close as Hugh ever got to being sentimental out loud. I understood, holding it, that it wasn't really about chess.

Theo gave me a drawing he'd made of the two of us on the hillside with Hugh's dog, badly proportioned and completely wonderful, which I still have pinned above my desk. Poppy gave me a small trophy she'd apparently 3D-printed at school specifically that said WORLD'S OKAYEST CHESS PLAYER, in retaliation, she informed me, for beating literally everybody in the harvest tournament.

My mom's gift was the smallest and the biggest at the same time — a new photograph, one she'd had printed from a copy Aaron had found somewhere in the wreckage of our old email accounts, of me and my dad at some birthday years earlier, both of us laughing at something out of frame, the same laugh I'd later find folded into my own sock on the night before we left New York.

"I thought you should have a newer one," she said. "One that's not falling apart at the folds."

I hugged her for a long time in front of basically the entire village, which normally I would have found mortifying at twelve years old, except right then I didn't care even a little bit.

By Lynden Pennington

Later that evening, sitting on Hugh's back step with a full stomach and a headache from laughing too much, I thought about how strange it was to be turning twelve in a field two thousand miles from where I was born, surrounded by people who'd been strangers less than half a year earlier. It didn't feel strange anymore, though. It just felt like my birthday, in my life, with my people. I think that might have been the exact moment I stopped counting the days since the crash and started just living the days instead.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Twenty-Six: Too Close

The news came in the middle of January, on a gray Tuesday that started out exactly like every other gray Tuesday that winter, and ended with half the village crammed into Frank's shop listening to a radio broadcast none of us would forget for a long time.

The Netherlands-Belgium Union — an alliance most of us barely knew existed until that winter, formed somewhere in the chaos of the war's early months — had launched a surprise offensive across the North Sea, aimed squarely at Britain. Nobody had expected it, least of all, it seemed, the people whose job it was to expect exactly that sort of thing. The newsreader's voice, usually so careful and measured, had an edge to it that made the whole shop go still.

"They're saying it caught the Navy off guard," Frank said, turning the radio up, his usual cheerful shopkeeper's manner completely gone. "Whole fleet moved faster than anyone predicted."

For three days, the news only got worse. The enemy ships and aircraft kept closing the distance, mile by mile, the newsreaders marking the gap the way you'd count down to something you didn't want to arrive at all. Two hundred miles. Then a hundred and fifty. Sheila stopped serving in the evenings and just kept the radio on instead, and I noticed my mom checking her phone more in those three days than she had in the entire year since the crash.

"Are we going to be okay?" I asked her, on the second night, the same question I'd asked her back in New York what felt like a lifetime earlier.

"I don't know, baby," she said, and this time she didn't pretend otherwise, which somehow scared me more than any of the news reports had. "I think

this is a scary few days. I think we get through scary days the same way we've gotten through all the others so far."

By the third day, the reports said the Union's forces had closed to within three hundred miles of the British coast — close enough that Hugh spent an entire afternoon quietly checking the old cellar under his farmhouse, close enough that Reverend Payne opened the church at all hours for anyone who wanted somewhere to sit with their fear instead of carrying it alone. I remember standing in the school yard that morning and looking up at a perfectly ordinary gray sky, trying to imagine it any other way, and not quite managing it.

Then, on the fourth day, everything changed at once.

The British military — Navy and Air Force together, in an operation the news would spend the next several weeks explaining in careful, technical detail — met the Union's advancing fleet head-on, still well out over open water, and in the space of a single night, turned back an invasion that three days earlier had looked, to everyone in that shop, disturbingly close to actually reaching us.

The broadcast that finally confirmed it, late that fourth evening, was almost too much for the shop to process all at once — the Union's fleet not just repelled but effectively destroyed, its capacity to threaten Britain gone within a matter of hours. Frank had to sit down on his own stool behind the counter. Sheila cried, openly, the way she never usually let herself in front of customers. My mom held onto me so tight I could feel her heart going, even after the danger itself had already passed.

"They did it," Hugh said, quietly, into the stunned silence of the shop. "They actually did it."

By Lynden Pennington

Nobody cheered, exactly, not that first night. It felt too close, too recent, too much like something we'd all be feeling the edges of for a long while yet. But there was a lightness in the village over the days that followed that I hadn't felt since before the crash, a kind of loosening in everybody's shoulders, like a held breath finally, cautiously, being let out.

I thought a great deal, in the weeks after, about how strange it was that a war so enormous could still come down, in the end, to a village shop radio and a room full of people holding their breath together, three hundred miles feeling, for those few days, like the entire distance between everything we had left and losing it completely.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Twenty-Seven: Lambing Season

That first spring, Hugh asked me if I wanted to help with lambing season, which is apparently the busiest, most exhausting, most important time of year on a sheep farm, when basically every single ewe decides to have her babies within about three weeks of each other, mostly at two in the morning, mostly all at once. It felt good, honestly, to have something that ordinary to think about after January — after the Union's ships had come and gone, after three days of holding our breath in Frank's shop. Lambs being born felt like exactly the right kind of thing to be worrying about instead.

"You don't have to," he said, the way he always offered things, like he expected me to say no and wanted to make it easy. "But you've a steady pair of hands, and I could use them."

I said yes before he'd even finished the sentence.

For two straight weeks, I woke up at five in the morning and biked over to Hugh's farm before school, and some nights I stayed there past dark too, checking on ewes in the lambing shed, learning how to tell which ones were close by the way they walked, how to help pull a stuck lamb free when a birth wasn't going smoothly, how to warm up a lamb that had come out too cold and too still and needed rubbing back to life with an old towel and a lot of patience.

The first time I watched a lamb take its first wobbly steps, less than an hour after being born, legs shaking like it wasn't sure yet whether the whole standing-up thing was going to work out, I actually got a little choked up, which I hadn't expected and definitely didn't tell anybody about, except I

think Hugh noticed anyway, because he just handed me a mug of tea without saying anything and let me have the moment.

There was one lamb, born weak, smaller than the rest, that Hugh let me bottle-feed every few hours for a week straight because her mother wouldn't take to her. I named her Egg, for no good reason except that it was the first word that came into my head, and Hugh laughed so hard the first time I said it that his dog got worried and started barking at both of us.

"Egg," he repeated, shaking his head. "Well. She's yours then, I suppose. Least as much as any sheep belongs to anybody."

Egg grew up fine, eventually, stronger than anybody expected, and got a habit of following me around the field whenever I visited, bumping her head against my leg like a request for attention, which Theo found absolutely hilarious and never once let me forget.

My mom asked me one evening, watching me fall asleep at the dinner table from exhaustion, whether I was doing too much, taking on too much responsibility for an eleven-year-old — twelve, by then, technically, though the birthday had come and gone so quietly I'd barely noticed it myself.

"I like it," I told her, which was true, though it took me a while to figure out exactly why. I think it was because for two weeks straight, my hands were full of something that needed me, something urgent and real and completely unconnected to the crash, to the war, to any of it. Just a small, cold, shaking lamb that needed warming up, and me, there, able to actually help.

That's a good feeling, when you've spent a long time feeling like there was nothing you could do about any of the biggest things happening around you. Turns out you don't always need to fix the biggest things. Sometimes

you just need one small, shaking thing that needs exactly what you have to give.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Twenty-Eight: The Crash Site

I went back to the actual crash site alone, just once, about eight months in, without telling anybody where I was going.

By then, the wreckage had long since been cleared away by recovery crews — every piece of the plane catalogued and removed, the black scar in the grass slowly filling back in with new growth, so that if you didn't already know what had happened there, you might have walked right past it and never guessed. Hugh had let the sheep back into that section of the field months earlier, and they grazed there now like it was any other patch of ground, which I found strangely comforting rather than strange.

I sat down in the grass in roughly the spot where I thought our row of seats had come to rest, though it was hard to be sure exactly, and just stayed there for a while, not really thinking about anything specific, just letting the wind move over the field the way it must have moved over it a thousand times before that one terrible morning, and a thousand times since.

I'd brought the second chess knight with me, the one Hugh had carved for my birthday, and I set it down in the grass for a minute, not sure why, some instinct I didn't fully examine. Then I picked it back up, because it felt wrong to leave it there, like it belonged with me and not with the field.

I thought about the ninety-five names. I still didn't know most of them by heart, not really, but I thought about the shape of what they'd lost — birthdays they wouldn't have, kids they wouldn't get to see grow up, ordinary Tuesday mornings they wouldn't get to complain about. I thought about the old couple who'd been married fifty-one years, holding hands right until the end, and hoped, in whatever way you can hope for something that's already happened, that it hadn't hurt too much, that it had been fast.

By Lynden Pennington

I didn't cry, which surprised me a little. I think I'd expected to. Instead I felt something quieter — not peace, exactly, because I don't think a field like that ever gives you full peace, but something close to it. A kind of settling, the same word my mom used sometimes for how she felt about the war ending. I understood, sitting there, that this field was always going to be part of my story, the same way New York was, the same way Thornfield Beck had become — not something to get over, exactly, but something to carry, the way you carry anything heavy that's also, somehow, yours.

Hugh found me there an hour later, out checking his fences, and didn't ask why I'd come or how long I'd been sitting. He just sat down next to me in the grass, his dog flopping down between us, and we stayed there together another twenty minutes without either of us saying much of anything.

"Doesn't look like much anymore, does it," he said eventually, looking out at the ordinary green field, the grazing sheep, the hills beyond.

"No," I agreed. "It doesn't."

"That's not forgetting," he said, like he'd read my mind. "Grass grows over most things, given time. Doesn't mean the ground forgets what happened on it. Just means it learned how to keep going anyway."

I thought that was probably the truest thing anybody had said to me the entire year, and Hugh, typically, seemed a little embarrassed to have said something that deep out loud, and changed the subject to a fence post that needed replacing before I could tell him so.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Twenty-Nine: Sports Day on the Green

Every June, apparently, the whole village turned out for something called Sports Day, held right on the village green in front of the church, and it turned out to be about a hundred times more chaotic and a hundred times more fun than anything my old school back in New York had ever organized.

There were the normal races — sack races, three-legged races, a relay that Poppy's team won so decisively the other teams basically gave up trying to compete with her — but there was also, for reasons nobody could really explain to me, an event called Welly Wanging, which is exactly what it sounds like: you throw a rubber boot as far as you possibly can, and whoever throws it farthest wins. Frank held the current village record, a fact he brought up constantly and defended fiercely every single year.

I entered the three-legged race with Theo, our ankles tied together with an old scarf of Sheila's, and we fell down twice, hard, laughing so much neither of us could actually run properly, and finished dead last by a wide margin, to absolutely no one's surprise, including our own.

Hugh entered the tug-of-war, anchoring one end of the rope for the farmers' team, and watching him dig his heels in against six grown men on the other side, not budging an inch, was honestly one of the most impressive things I'd ever seen a person do. He won. Obviously he won. Sheila cheered so loud for him that half the village turned to look, and Hugh went red the exact same way he had at Christmas, which made me and Theo laugh so hard we nearly fell down a third time. At one point, high overhead, a formation of aircraft passed far to the north, distant enough to be barely more than a low hum, and I noticed a few of the older villagers

glance up out of old habit before going right back to their tea, the way you'd check the sky for rain and then get on with your afternoon regardless of what you saw.

We didn't find out what that formation had actually been until that evening, gathered around Frank's shop radio along with half the village, listening to a newsreader's careful, measured voice describe a bomber that had crossed into American airspace from the German front and struck near Washington, D.C., before being intercepted and brought down over the Atlantic by a fighter jet scrambled out of London. Nobody in the shop said much of anything while it played. My mom's hand found my shoulder without either of us really deciding it should.

"They got it before it could do worse," Frank said, finally, switching off the radio once the report moved on to something else. "That's the part to hold onto, lad. They got it."

I thought about that a great deal afterward — how something so enormous, so far away, could still reach all the way into a village hall in the north of England and settle over a room full of people eating shepherd's pie, and how strange it was that the same aircraft none of us had thought twice about at Sports Day had turned out to be part of something so much bigger than any of us watching it drift by that afternoon could have possibly known.

My mom, to my complete and utter shock, entered the mothers' race and actually placed second, sprinting across the green in bare feet because her shoes had come off somewhere around the halfway mark, her hair coming loose from its ponytail, laughing the entire way in a way I hadn't seen her laugh since long before the crash — really laugh, the kind that takes over your whole face and you can't stop even if you wanted to.

By Lynden Pennington

“I used to run track,” she told me afterward, out of breath, cheeks bright red. “High school. I forgot I still had that in me.”

“You looked ridiculous,” I told her, grinning.

“I looked *magnificent*,” she said, and did a little victory spin that made Sheila cheer even louder than she had for Hugh.

We ate ice cream from a van that showed up specifically for the occasion, and Reverend Payne got absolutely soaked during a water balloon toss he was clearly not supposed to be participating in, and by the time the sun started going down over the hills, I realized I’d laughed more in one single afternoon than I think I had in the entire year before it. Not forgetting anything. Not pretending the crash hadn’t happened, or that the war wasn’t still out there somewhere, grinding on. Just laughing anyway, in the middle of it all, because Thornfield Beck seemed to have this whole philosophy built right into its bones: that joy and grief could sit right next to each other on the same green, on the same afternoon, and neither one had to cancel the other one out.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Thirty: What the Village Carried

In the weeks after that scary night, I started noticing something I'd been too wrapped up in my own stuff to really see before — that everybody in Thornfield Beck who'd been so kind to us had their own hard stories underneath it, quiet ones, the kind you only find out about sideways, from somebody else, on a slow afternoon.

Sheila had lost her husband in a fishing accident years before we ever showed up, and raised her two daughters alone above the pub, working double shifts and somehow still managing to show up to every single school play and football match either of them ever had. Turns out she poured tea for strangers the way she did because she knew exactly what it felt like to need somebody to hand you a cup without asking you to explain yourself first.

Dr. Okonkwo-Bell had lost her own brother, a long time ago, in a different kind of disaster in a different part of the world — she mentioned it to me once, only briefly, the way you mention an old injury that still aches sometimes when it rains, and then changed the subject so fast I understood I wasn't meant to ask any follow-up questions.

Frank had lost his whole shop once already, to a fire eleven years back, and rebuilt it from nothing, sleeping some nights on a cot in the half-finished building just so he could keep working on it every spare hour he had. "Not because I had some big plan for surviving it, lad," he told me while I helped him restock tins one slow afternoon. "There just wasn't really any other direction to walk except forward. So forward's the direction I walked."

Even Reverend Payne, I found out much later from Sheila, had come to Thornfield Beck eight years before, young and a little broken by something

he never fully talked about either, and the village had put him back together the exact same patient way it was now putting my mom and me back together — one visit, one cup of tea, one quiet conversation at a time.

“We’re not special, love,” Sheila told me once, wiping down the bar in that same unhurried way. “Every village like this has its own losses, same as every person does, if you dig down far enough. The only trick — and it’s not even much of a trick — is deciding you’re going to keep the door open anyway. That’s really all kindness is, when you look at it plain.”

I thought about that a lot, about how easy it would have been for this whole village to just look the other way when a plane fell out of the sky into their sheep pasture. They didn’t. They opened the door instead, even though every single one of them already knew exactly what it can cost you to let people in.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Thirty-One: Theo's Dad Comes Home

It was almost a full year before Theo's dad finally came home, and when the day actually arrived, the whole village found out about it roughly four minutes after Yasmin did, because Sheila's pub had basically become the unofficial news network of Thornfield Beck, and good news traveled through it faster than anything else ever had.

Theo had told me it might happen "any day now" for about three straight weeks, which is a hard thing for a kid to sit with, that particular kind of waiting where you're afraid to get too excited in case it slips away again. So when my mom got the actual call from Yasmin — *he's here, he's really here, come to the green* — we dropped everything and ran.

Half the village was already gathering on the green by the time we got there, which is a strange thing to picture, a whole community turning out just to watch one man walk down a lane, but that's exactly what happened. Frank had closed the shop early. Sheila had left the pub unattended, an event Hugh later swore he'd never witnessed before in his life. Even Mrs. Renwick let school out ten minutes early, marching the whole class down to the green together like it was a field trip.

Theo's dad — I only knew him from photographs until that day — came around the bend in a car that Hugh had driven up from the train station, and the second the door opened, Theo took off running so fast I couldn't have caught him if I'd tried.

I won't describe the whole thing in detail, because some moments belong to the people living them and not really to anybody watching. But I'll say this: Theo's dad walked with a limp he didn't have before, and there was a scar along one side of his face that hadn't been there in the photographs, and

none of that mattered even a little bit once Theo reached him, because his dad just dropped straight down onto the grass on his knees and wrapped both arms around him and didn't let go for what felt like a full minute, the whole green gone completely silent except for Yasmin, who'd started crying the second the car door opened and hadn't stopped since.

Afterward, once the crowd had mostly given the family some space, Hugh came and stood next to me and my mom, watching from a little ways off, and he didn't say anything for a long time.

"Not everybody gets that," he said, finally, quiet, and I knew he wasn't just talking about Theo.

"No," my mom agreed. "They don't."

I thought about my own dad, who I hadn't seen in years, for reasons that had nothing to do with war or planes or anything so dramatic — just a marriage that had simply run out of road, the way my mom always put it. I wasn't waiting for a homecoming like Theo's. But watching Theo get his anyway, I found I didn't feel jealous, exactly. I felt something more like hope on his behalf, and a little bit of hope for myself too, the quiet kind that doesn't need anything specific to be hoping for.

That night, the whole village ended up back at the pub, uninvited, unplanned, just because that's where everybody instinctively went when something good happened, the same way they'd all shown up in the field when something terrible had. Sheila didn't charge anybody for a single drink. I don't think she even tried to keep track.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Thirty-Two: The Anniversary

A year went by. I grew two inches. I finally won the village chess tournament for real, no suspiciously convenient losses from Frank this time. The roses out back bloomed wild in June, and I'd learned to work the old stove without setting off the smoke alarm.

The war hadn't fully ended, but it had settled into something quieter, less dramatic — the kind of ongoing thing that stops making headlines but keeps grinding on anyway, somewhere over the horizon.

Reverend Payne asked if my mom and I would want to speak at the church's anniversary service marking the crash, and my mom said yes before really thinking it through, and then spent three weeks nervous about it. In the end, it was me who wrote something — I didn't tell her until the morning of, when I handed her a single sheet of notebook paper and asked if I could read it myself.

"You don't have to," she said.

"I want to," I told her, and something in my own voice surprised me — steadier than I'd sounded in a long time.

The church was packed that evening, every pew full, people standing along the back wall near the old wooden doors. It was the same church where we'd sat a year earlier learning the names of ninety-five strangers, and it looked almost exactly the same — same cold stone, same candles guttering a little in the draft from the door — except this time it didn't feel like a place holding its breath. It felt like a place that had exhaled, slowly, over the course of a whole year, and was finally ready to breathe normally again.

By Lynden Pennington

I stood up front, small against the old stone arch behind me, and for a second, right before I started, I couldn't find my voice at all. I just stood there with the paper shaking a little in my hand, looking out at every single face I'd come to know over the last twelve months — faces that had been strangers in a field once, and weren't anymore. My mom caught my eye from the second pew and gave me this tiny nod, the kind that doesn't say "hurry up," just "I'm right here." That was enough. I unfolded the paper.

"A year ago," I read, my voice shaking a little at first and then steadying out, "a plane fell out of the sky into Mr. Alderton's field, and ninety-five people didn't get to keep living, and ninety-one of us did, and I've spent a whole year trying to understand why, and I still don't." I paused there, longer than I meant to, because saying that number out loud in front of everyone hit different than just thinking it alone at night. Nobody moved. Nobody rushed me. "But I know what happened after. A farmer ran into a field to help strangers before he even knew if it was safe. A whole village gave away its blankets and its soup and its spare bedrooms to people it had never met. A kid taught me how to be less scared just by needing me to sit with him. And I think maybe that's the actual answer, even if it's not the answer to the question I was asking. Maybe the question isn't why some of us got to keep living. Maybe the question is just what you do with the living you get to keep. I think, this year, we tried to do something good with it. I think Thornfield Beck did too."

I folded the paper back up slowly, giving myself a second before I had to look up. When I did, I looked out at everyone — Hugh, who had his cap pressed flat against his chest with both hands; Sheila, dabbing at her eyes with the corner of her sleeve and not even pretending not to; Theo and his mom, sitting close together; Frank; Dr. Okonkwo-Bell; Reverend Payne, nodding slow from the side of the church; and my own mom, crying openly in the second pew with no dish towel to hide it in this time. "Thank you for

the year," I said, and sat back down beside her. She pulled me against her and held on, the same way she had in the field, the same way she had every night since, except this time it wasn't out of fear. It was out of something that had quietly turned into gratitude instead, and I could feel it in the way she held on — looser than fear, warmer, like she wasn't afraid of losing me anymore, just glad to have me.

Afterward, outside the church, half the village lined up just to hug me or shake my hand, which felt strange and enormous and, in its own way, exactly right. Hugh didn't say anything at all. He just put one big hand on my shoulder for a second, squeezed once, and let go, and somehow that told me more than any of the words everyone else had used.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Thirty-Three: A Voice from the Fire Escape

Deshawn's message came two days after the anniversary service — fourteen months of silence, all broken at once by a single voice message I played so many times that week I basically memorized it by accident, walking around the cottage muttering it under my breath until my mom asked if I was practicing a speech.

Yo, Milo, it's me, I got your number from your mom finally, sorry it took forever, everything's crazy but we're okay, me and my mom and my sister, we had to move to my aunt's for a while but we're back now. The building's still standing. Your old apartment's boarded up but everybody else is back. I skate past it sometimes, it's weird. Anyway I finally got good at kickflips, you're gonna be so mad you missed it. Call me back, I miss you, man. I really do.

I cried listening to it, for real, for the first time about anything connected to my old life instead of the crash itself. My mom said that was its own kind of anniversary — not of losing something this time, but of loving two places at once and not being able to fully live in either one.

We video-called that weekend, the connection freezing and stuttering the whole time so that half of what Deshawn said arrived a beat later than his mouth moving, which somehow made it even funnier. I fell right back into the same easy rhythm with him we'd always had — him describing the kickflip in way too much detail, complete with sound effects, me telling him about Theo and Hugh's dog and the chess tournament, both of us grinning the entire time like no time at all had passed, even though basically an entire other lifetime had happened to both of us since we'd last spoken.

By Lynden Pennington

“You have to come visit,” Deshawn said near the end. “Or I gotta come there. I looked up your village on a map, it’s like, in the middle of nowhere, there’s more sheep than people, how do you even survive.”

“You get used to it,” I told him. “It’s actually really good here, D. I know that’s weird to say. But it is.”

“That’s not weird,” he said, after a second, more serious than I expected. “My mom says sometimes the worst thing that happens to you also shows you people you wouldn’t have found otherwise. She says that’s not the same as being glad it happened. It’s just — the two things can both be true.”

I’ve thought about that sentence probably a thousand times since. I think Deshawn’s mom might be one of the smartest people I’ve never actually met.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Thirty-Four: Aunt Renata Comes North

Aunt Renata finally made it to Thornfield Beck in the spring, almost a year and a half after the crash, once flights had started working again. She showed up by train and then a car up our winding little road, and I watched her step out and just stand there in the lane, staring at the stone cottages and the hills, this look on her face I couldn't quite figure out until she finally spoke.

"I pictured you somewhere smaller than this," she told my mom. "Sadder. I think I built this whole place in my head as a — a waiting room. Somewhere you were stuck until you could finally get to me." She looked around again, eyes a little wet. "This isn't a waiting room, is it."

"No," my mom said. "It stopped being that a while ago."

Renata stayed a week, and I watched her fall under the same spell the village had put on us. She'd never met any of them before, but by day three she was drinking Sheila's sweet tea like she'd been raised on it, losing badly at chess to me in the back garden, and sitting for two whole hours in Hugh's kitchen listening to him talk about Daniel in a way I later learned he almost never did with anybody. She cried a little when Hugh showed her the wall we'd been mending together all year, running her fingers along the stones like she could feel, somehow, exactly how much time and care had gone into stacking them.

On her last night, she and my mom sat out in the garden while I pretended to be asleep upstairs but was actually listening through the cracked window, because I'm eleven — well, twelve by then — and that's just what you do.

By Lynden Pennington

“I still think you should come to Zurich,” Renata said. “Not because this is a waiting room. Because I miss my sister. And my nephew.”

“I know,” my mom said. “I think about it, Ren. I do.” She was quiet for a second. “But I keep coming back to the same thing. I didn’t choose this place. It chose us, in the worst possible way, and then it just kept choosing us, in a hundred small ways I never could have arranged myself. I don’t know how to explain that without it sounding insane.”

“It doesn’t sound insane,” Renata said, quiet. “It sounds like you found something. I’m not going to be the one who tells you to leave it behind twice.”

I fell asleep before I heard the rest, but I already knew, somehow, what my mom had decided. I think I’d known for a long time.

Renata left the next morning with a bag full of Frank’s cinnamon sweets she’d insisted on buying “for the flight,” and a promise from my mom that we’d visit Zurich that summer, which we did, eventually — a strange, wonderful, disorienting week of mountains and lakes and a life that could have been ours, if things had gone even slightly differently. But I remember, standing on the platform watching Renata’s train pull away, feeling something I hadn’t expected to feel: relief, that we were staying, and not one bit of guilt about feeling that way.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Thirty-Five: Deshawn Visits

It took almost two full years, but Deshawn actually made it to Thornfield Beck in person, flying over with his mom for what was supposed to be a ten-day visit and turned into two full weeks because, in his words, “there’s nothing to fly home for anyway, it’s not like I’m missing much.”

I met him at the train station in Alnhaven, and for about four seconds we just stood there looking at each other, both of us taller and older and different than the last time we’d stood in the same room, and then he grinned his same old grin and said, “You got a British accent or something, bro?” and it was like no time had passed at all.

He was obsessed with everything about the village, in the specific, loud, delighted way only Deshawn could be obsessed with something. He wanted to see the field first, insisting on it before we’d even dropped his bags off, and stood there for a long time just staring at the ordinary green grass, shaking his head slowly.

“This is it?” he said. “This is where you fell out of the sky?”

“This is it.”

“It’s just grass, man.”

“Yeah,” I said. “That’s kind of the whole thing about it.”

He met Theo and immediately declared him “aggressively British,” which Theo took as a huge compliment and adopted as a personal catchphrase for the rest of the visit. He lost badly to Frank at chess, badly to me at chess, and — most infuriatingly, according to him — badly to Poppy in a footrace across the green, a defeat he brought up roughly nine more times over the

following two weeks in increasingly creative attempts to get a rematch he never won.

Hugh let him help with the sheep, and Deshawn, who had approximately zero farm experience, managed to get chased by an unusually opinionated ewe within his first ten minutes in the pasture, a story that Sheila retold at the pub so many times over those two weeks that by the end, Deshawn was doing the reenactment himself, complete with sound effects, for anybody who'd sit still long enough to watch.

One evening, near the end of the trip, we sat out on the roof of Hugh's old shed, the same one I still climbed sometimes to think, and Deshawn got quiet in a way that wasn't really like him.

"I get it now," he said. "Why you didn't come back. I thought maybe you just got, like, comfortable, or forgot about home or whatever. But it's not that. This is home too. I can see it. It's in how everybody talks to you here. Like you belong to them a little bit."

"I do belong to them a little bit," I said. "Doesn't mean I stopped belonging to New York too."

"Yeah," he said. "I figured that out about halfway through Sheila's third retelling of the sheep thing."

We laughed about that for a while, and then just sat there quiet, looking out at the hills going dark, the same hills I'd once thought looked like nothing more than an accident of geography. When his mom picked him up for the airport two days later, he hugged me the same way he had on our old fire escape, hard and fast, like ripping off a bandage, and yelled "SEE YOU, IDIOT" out the car window the whole way down the lane until I couldn't hear him anymore, which felt, somehow, exactly like it was supposed to — like a circle closing, gently, instead of breaking.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Thirty-Six: The Knight

Two years after the crash, on a regular Saturday in September, my mom found me sitting out in the back garden among the roses — thriving now, thanks to me, actually — turning that same chess knight over in my fingers. The one I'd been holding when the plane went down. It had survived the crash, the recovery crews, two years of pockets and drawers, and one memorable trip through the washing machine that somehow didn't destroy it, though it did come out looking slightly more battered than before, which I decided just made it look tougher.

"You still carry that thing everywhere," she said, sitting down next to me on the old stone bench, the one that had been there since long before we arrived and would probably be there long after.

"Not everywhere. Just sometimes." I held it up in the light. "I used to think it was lucky. Like it was the reason we survived, so I had to keep holding it or something bad would happen."

"And now?"

I thought about that seriously, the way I think about everything now, thirteen years old, taller than my mom had quite adjusted to, my voice not quite settled into whatever it was eventually going to become. "Now I think I just keep it because it was there. Before and after. It's not lucky. It's just — proof, I guess. That the before actually happened. That it was really me, not some different kid with a different life back in New York. This is proof it was me."

My mom put her arm around me, careful now that I was almost her height, careful in the way you get when the person you're hugging isn't small anymore but you still remember, clearly, exactly how small they used to be.

By Lynden Pennington

“You don’t need proof, you know. I remember. I’ll always remember, for both of us, if you ever need me to.”

“I know.” I leaned into her anyway. “I think I just like having something to hold sometimes. Doesn’t have to mean more than that.”

I didn’t even realize until later that I’d basically just repeated something Hugh once told my mom about the wall — how you soak up stuff like that from the people who help raise you, until you can’t quite remember anymore which words were originally yours and which ones you borrowed from somebody standing nearby during the hardest year of your life. I think that’s just what family ends up being, in the end, whether it’s the family you’re born with or the one you happen to fall out of the sky into. A collection of borrowed sentences, passed hand to hand, until you can’t tell anymore where any one person’s words end and somebody else’s begin.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Thirty-Seven: Passing It On

Three years after the crash, a family showed up in Thornfield Beck the same way we had — not by plane this time, but by a long, exhausting road journey out of a different corner of the war, a mother and her daughter who'd lost everything else and ended up, through some tangle of relief agencies and lucky connections, placed in our village because a cottage two doors from the church happened to be empty.

The daughter's name was Amara. She was nine, quiet in the specific, careful way I recognized immediately, the way you get quiet when you're not sure yet whether it's safe to be anything else.

Reverend Payne asked, gently, if I'd be willing to show her around, the way Hugh and Theo and half the village had once shown me around, and I said yes before he'd even finished asking, understanding all at once, in a way I hadn't quite let myself understand before, exactly what Hugh must have felt walking up on our wrecked plane three years earlier — that particular, specific need to just go and help, without waiting to be sure it was your job to do it.

I took her to the field first, the same way Deshawn had wanted to see it, except this time I understood why somebody in her position might need to see it differently — not as a landmark, but as proof. Proof that a field can stop being the worst place in the world and turn into just a field again, given time.

I introduced her to Hugh's new border collie, who took to her immediately, the way dogs always seemed to know exactly who needed a dog most. I brought her by Frank's shop, and he snuck her a cinnamon sweet exactly

the way he'd once snuck them to me, like it was our secret, like he hadn't done the same thing for a dozen kids before either of us.

I didn't push her to talk. I remembered too well how much I hadn't wanted to talk, that first month, how every gentle question from a well-meaning adult had felt like being asked to hand over something too raw to be handled yet. I just showed up. I let her walk beside me in silence when that's what she needed, and I answered questions when she finally started asking them, weeks later, mostly about the village, sometimes, carefully, about the crash.

"Does it stop," she asked me once, months in, sitting on the same stone bench in my mom's rose garden where I'd once turned my own chess knight over and over in my hands. "The scared feeling. At night."

"It gets further apart," I told her, using almost exactly my mom's old words, understanding for the first time how a sentence can travel all the way through a person and come out the other side sounding like your own. "It doesn't go away all at once. It just gets quieter."

She nodded, the way I imagine I once nodded at my mom, not quite believing it yet but wanting to.

Sheila started teaching her to make tea properly within the month. Hugh, without ever quite admitting it out loud, started finding reasons for her to help with the sheep. My mom and Amara's mother became close fast, bonded by the specific, wordless understanding of two women who'd rebuilt an entire life out of one bag each.

I thought, watching all of it happen, about something Sheila had told me years earlier — that Thornfield Beck wasn't special for what it had done for us, only for deciding, every single time, to keep the door open anyway. I understood now that being on the other side of that door, holding it open

myself, was its own kind of gift, maybe an even bigger one than the one I'd received. Some kindnesses, it turns out, aren't finished until you get to pass them on.

By Lynden Pennington

Chapter Thirty-Eight: Thornfield Beck

The war ended, eventually, the slow unsatisfying way most wars probably end — not one big peace announcement, but a bunch of ceasefires that gradually stopped breaking, until one Tuesday morning a headline just confirmed what regular life had already been quietly telling everybody for months: the worst of it was over.

I read that headline over eggs, the same breakfast ritual my mom and I had kept up since that very first morning back on 111th Street, four whole years earlier by then, and I didn't feel the huge relief I always imagined I'd feel. I felt something quieter instead. A kind of settling. The war ending didn't undo any of what happened during it. It didn't bring back the ninety-five names. It didn't un-condemn our old apartment. But it also didn't erase the two years of nightmares that had, exactly like my mom promised, gotten further and further apart until they became rare.

My mom read the headline twice, set her phone down on the table, and just looked out the kitchen window for a while at the hills going green in the early summer light, not saying anything. I didn't ask what she was thinking. Some quiet, I'd learned by then, doesn't need to be filled in.

I was sixteen by then, tall and quiet, still playing chess with Frank every single Sunday, still walking the hills with Hugh's new dog — the old collie had passed a couple winters back, and honestly, the whole village mourned him, Sheila closing the pub early that day out of respect, which told you something about how much even a dog could matter in a place like Thornfield Beck. I still had the knight, though it mostly lived in a drawer by then, taken out less for comfort and more just for the simple pleasure of remembering.

By Lynden Pennington

Theo, thirteen now, was still basically my other half, though he'd finally stopped narrating his own life out loud, mostly, except when he was really excited about something. His dad had fully recovered and was back working the family farm. Yasmin had become one of my mom's closest friends, the two of them bonded by a field they'd both survived and a village that had turned survivors into neighbors, and neighbors into something a lot closer to family.

Deshawn had visited twice by then. The second time, he stood with me in Hugh's pasture, staring at the totally unremarkable grass that had once opened up to catch a falling plane, and said, quiet, "I get it now. Why you stayed." I didn't need to explain any further than that.

On a warm evening in early June, I walked out into the back garden and found my mom standing among roses she'd stopped thinking of as Mrs. Tavistock's a long time ago and started thinking of as just hers, watching the light go gold over the same hills that had once seemed, on the worst morning of our whole lives, like nothing more than a random accident of geography — some stretch of English countryside that happened to be underneath a falling plane.

I don't think either of us sees it that way anymore. I think we both see it the way Reverend Payne once described the whole village: not a place that did anything remarkable in taking us in, but a place that simply did what you do — opened its doors, poured the tea, mended the wall, held the kid through the long nights, and got up the next morning and did it all over again, until two strangers who fell out of the sky became, without any single big moment marking the change, just people who belonged.

I brought her out a cup of Sheila's tea, sweet, the way you make it for someone in shock, even though neither of us had been in shock for a long, long time. We sat together on the old stone bench and watched the hills

turn from gold to purple to that deep settled blue you only get on a summer evening, not needing to say much of anything, because we already knew — we were, finally, completely, safely, home.

Somewhere down the lane, Sheila's pub let out a burst of laughter through an open window, and a dog barked twice, and somebody's kettle whistled, and none of it needed explaining anymore, because it was just the sound of the place we lived.

THE END

By Lynden Pennington

Author's Note

This story is fiction — Milo, Clare, Thornfield Beck, and the war they lived through are all made up. But the situations in this book are grounded in real history and real science, the same way the true *I Survived* books are grounded in real disasters.

Evacuating children away from cities during wartime is very real. During the Second World War, Britain evacuated more than three million children out of London and other major cities, sending them to live with host families in the countryside, sometimes for years, in an operation called Operation Pied Piper. Many of those children were taken in by complete strangers, in villages a lot like Thornfield Beck, and some of those host families stayed close with the children they sheltered for the rest of their lives.

Plane crash survival is also real, and often more survivable than people expect. Aviation safety experts have found that the vast majority of passengers in survivable plane accidents do get out alive, especially when they listen to safety briefings, know their nearest exit, and move quickly once the aircraft stops moving. The brace position taught in this book is a real technique, used because it protects your head and reduces injury during a sudden impact.

The nightmares and fear Milo experiences after the crash describe something real too, called post-traumatic stress, which can affect anyone — kids included — after living through something frightening or dangerous. It's common, it's treatable, and it does get better with time and support, exactly the way Milo's mom promises him it will.

By Lynden Pennington

Most of all, this book is about something else that's real: that ordinary communities, even small ones, are often more capable of extraordinary kindness than we expect — and that when disaster strikes, it's rarely a single hero who gets people through it. It's usually a whole village.

By Lynden Pennington

About the Author

This book was written by Lynden, who loves creative writing and storytelling. This story started as an idea about a mother and son caught in a war and forced to flee — and grew, chapter by chapter, into the full novel you just read.

By Lynden Pennington

Quiz: Did You Survive the Story?

One question per chapter — see how much you remember!

Chapter 1 — Falling: What does Milo say he's holding onto so tightly during the crash that his knuckles hurt? A) His mom's hand B) A chess knight C) A photo D) His phone

Chapter 2 — Sirens: What does Clare do for a living? A) Nurse B) Shipping and logistics C) Teacher D) Pilot

Chapter 3 — The Word Nobody Wanted to Say: Who calls from Switzerland to tell them to come stay? A) Grandma B) Aaron C) Aunt Renata D) Deshawn

Chapter 4 — What Fits in One Bag: What does Milo keep folded in his sock? A) Money B) A photo of his dad C) A letter D) A map

Chapter 5 — JFK: What does the departure board keep flashing as flights disappear? A) DELAYED B) BOARDING C) CANCELLED D) ON TIME

Chapter 6 — Wheels Up: What does Milo whisper to the window as New York shrinks below? A) "I'll be back" B) "Bye, New York" C) "See you soon" D) He says nothing

Chapter 7 — The Sound Before the Sound: What does the pilot declare over the intercom? A) A delay B) A medical emergency C) An emergency, with damage sustained D) Turbulence

Chapter 8 — Impact: About how many of the 186 passengers survive the crash? A) All of them B) About half (91) C) Just a handful D) None

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Chapter 9 — The Field: Whose sheep field does the plane crash into? A) Frank's B) Reverend Payne's C) Hugh Alderton's D) Sheila's

Chapter 10 — The Long Walk: About how far do the survivors walk to reach the village? A) Half a mile B) Almost two miles C) Ten miles D) They don't walk; they're driven

Chapter 11 — The Village Hall: Who stitches the cut above Milo's eyebrow? A) Sheila B) Reverend Payne C) Dr. Okonkwo-Bell D) Hugh

Chapter 12 — The Names: What does the village hold on the third day? A) A wedding B) A remembering, for those who didn't survive C) A trial D) A parade

Chapter 13 — Nowhere to Go: Who offers Milo and his mom a cottage to live in? A) Hugh B) Frank C) Reverend Payne D) Sheila

Chapter 14 — Mrs. Tavistock's Cottage: What has taken over the cottage's back garden? A) Vegetables B) Wild roses C) A pond D) An old car

Chapter 15 — New Faces: What does the classmate Callum tease Milo about? A) His accent B) Whether he cried during the crash C) His clothes D) His grades

Chapter 16 — The Letter I Didn't Send: Who is Milo trying to write a letter to? A) His dad B) Aunt Renata C) Deshawn D) His grandma

Chapter 17 — Hugh's Boy: What was the name of Hugh's son, who died years earlier? A) Daniel B) Theo C) Frank D) Marc

Chapter 18 — What Comes Back at Night: What does Milo start experiencing about six weeks after the crash? A) Sleepwalking B) Nightmares C) Headaches D) Fevers

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Chapter 19 — The Harvest Festival: What does Milo win at the festival? A) A pie-eating contest B) The chess tournament C) A raffle D) A running race

Chapter 20 — The Storm: Who gets caught in the sudden storm with Milo? A) Deshawn B) Poppy C) Theo D) Hugh

Chapter 21 — News From Home: What happened to Milo and Clare's old New York apartment? A) Nothing, it's fine B) It was sold C) It was damaged in an attack and condemned D) It burned down

Chapter 22 — The Kid Who Wasn't Welcome: Who tells Milo that taking in the survivors "cost the village something"? A) Sheila B) Mrs. Pruitt, the flower seller C) Mrs. Renwick D) Frank

Chapter 23 — Blackout: Where does the village shelter during the December attack scare? A) The church B) The school C) The cellar under the pub D) Hugh's barn

Chapter 24 — Christmas at Thornfield Beck: What gift does Milo receive in the village gift exchange? A) A book B) A hand-carved wooden fox C) A scarf D) A chess set

Chapter 25 — Birthday in the Hills: What does Hugh give Milo for his twelfth birthday? A) A puppy B) A second chess knight C) A fishing rod D) Money

Chapter 26 — Lambing Season: What does Milo name the weak lamb he bottle-feeds? A) Egg B) Snowy C) Knight D) Pepper

Chapter 27 — The Crash Site: What does Milo bring with him when he visits the crash site alone? A) Flowers B) The second chess knight C) A letter D) Nothing

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Chapter 28 — Sports Day on the Green: What does Milo's mom place in during the festivities? A) Welly Wanging B) The mothers' race (second place) C) Tug-of-war D) The sack race

Chapter 29 — What the Village Carried: How did Sheila lose her husband, years before Milo and Clare arrived? A) A car accident B) A fishing accident C) An illness D) A fire

Chapter 30 — Theo's Dad Comes Home: Why does the whole village gather on the green? A) A wedding B) Theo's father returning home C) A holiday D) A funeral

Chapter 31 — The Anniversary: What does Milo do at the one-year remembering service? A) Sings a song B) Reads a speech he wrote himself C) Lights a candle silently D) Doesn't attend

Chapter 32 — A Voice from the Fire Escape: Who sends Milo a voice message after over a year of silence? A) His dad B) Deshawn C) Aunt Renata D) Callum

Chapter 33 — Aunt Renata Comes North: What does Renata realize Thornfield Beck is not, once she visits? A) A waiting room B) Safe C) Beautiful D) Far away

Chapter 34 — Deshawn Visits: What chases Deshawn in the sheep pasture? A) Hugh's dog B) An opinionated ewe C) A goose D) Nothing, he's exaggerating

Chapter 35 — The Knight: What does Milo decide the chess knight really means to him now? A) Good luck B) Proof that the "before" really happened C) Nothing anymore D) A gift from his dad

Chapter 36 — Passing It On: What is the name of the new girl Milo helps settle into the village? A) Poppy B) Egg C) Amara D) Theo

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Answer Key: 1) B 2) B 3) C 4) B 5) C 6) B 7) C 8) B 9) C 10) B 11) C 12) B 13) C 14) B 15) B 16) C 17) A 18) B 19) B 20) C 21) C 22) B 23) C 24) B 25) B 26) A 27) B 28) B 29) B 30) B 31) B 32) B 33) A 34) B 35) B 36) C